

Tamil, Step by Step, Root by Root

An etymology-driven curriculum, built one word at a time

Adhithya Rajasekaran

This edition compiled incrementally — new chapters added as they are written.

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Preface

This book teaches Tamil one word at a time, and it teaches each word by taking it apart. It is written for someone starting from zero — who may not read a single Tamil letter — so the script is taught *inside the word lessons themselves*: each word introduces exactly the letters it needs, so you learn to read **வணக்கம்** *and* learn that it means “greetings” in the same few minutes. There is no alphabet drill to sit through first.

Many readers will not be starting from zero at all. If you grew up speaking Tamil at home and never studied it — fluent in the language, hesitant with the letters, never once told *why* any of it works the way it does — this book is written for you as well. Skim the “letters in this word” notes for the handful of shapes you are unsure of, and read the rest for the grammar and the history nobody sat you down and explained.

Tamil rewards this depth more than most languages. It is the oldest-attested of the **Dravidian** tongues — a family entirely separate from the Indo-European one that gave us English, Latin, and Sanskrit — and it is famously protective of its own word-stock. Again and again you will find Tamil keeping a home-grown word (**வணக்கம்** *vaṇakkam*, “hello”; **நன்றி** *nanṇri*, “thanks”) where its sisters Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam reached for a Sanskrit one. So each lesson sets the word beside its cousins across the family — English always, and Sanskrit, Hindi, and the other Dravidian languages where they illuminate — every form supplied in full, so no prior knowledge of any of them is assumed.

How to use this book

Every numbered section is one word, or one small phrase, and takes a few minutes — the length of a queue, an errand, or the walk to the bus. Read them in order the first time through: each section stands on the ones before it, and nothing is used before it has been taught. After that the book becomes reference, and you can open it anywhere.

Say the Tamil out loud wherever you can. The prompts under *Your turn* are written to be spoken, and saying a word is most of what makes it stay. The questions under *Before you move on* carry their own answers in brackets: cover them, answer from memory, then look.

Nothing here is gated behind the alphabet. Each lesson introduces exactly the letters and sounds its own word needs, so you are reading real words from the first page rather than drilling a chart. The whole script is gathered in a reference at the back of the book — somewhere to look things up when you are curious, never a chapter to sit through first.

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Contents

Preface	iii
1 Greetings	1
1.1 வணக்கம் (<i>vaṇakkam</i>) — “greetings,” a small act of respect	1
1.2 நன்றி	2
1.3 ஆம் (<i>ām</i>) — “yes”	3
1.4 இல்லை (<i>illai</i>) — “no,” and how Tamil says a thing is <i>not</i> .	4
1.5 சரி (<i>sari</i>) — “okay,” the word that oils every conversation .	4
1.6 Recap, and how Tamil says goodbye	5
2 Introducing Yourself	7
2.1 பெயர் (<i>peyar</i>) — “name,” and where the family is <i>not</i> Indo-European	7
2.2 என் (<i>eṇ</i>) — “my”	8
2.3 என் பெயர் ... (<i>eṇ peyar ...</i>) — “my name is...,” with no “is”	8
2.4 நீ / நீங்கள்	9
2.5 என்ன (<i>eṇṇa</i>) — “what”	9
2.6 உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? (<i>uṇḡaḷ peyar eṇṇa</i>) — “what’s your name?”	10
2.7 மகிழ்ச்சி (<i>magilcci</i>) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you” . .	10
2.8 The whole exchange	10
3 How Are You?	13
3.1 எப்படி (<i>eppaṭi</i>) — “how,” another of the e- questions	13
3.2 நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்? — “how are you?”	14
3.3 நான் (<i>nāṇ</i>) — “I,” the Dravidian first person	14
3.4 நலம் (<i>naḷam</i>) — “well,” and how to answer	14
3.5 பரவாயில்லை (<i>paravāyillai</i>) — “no problem”	15
3.6 The whole exchange	15

4 Farewells	17
4.1 போ (<i>pō</i>) — “go,” and வா (come)	17
4.2 போய் வருகிறேன் (<i>pōy varugirēṇ</i>) — “I’ll go and come back”	17
4.3 நாளை பார்க்கலாம் (<i>nālai pārkkalām</i>) — “see you tomorrow”	18
4.4 மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம்	19
4.5 The farewells	19
5 The First Verbs	21
5.1 பேசு (<i>pēsu</i>) — “to speak,” your first full verb	21
5.2 நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் — “I speak Tamil”	22
5.3 வாழ் (<i>vāḷ</i>) — “to live, to flourish”	22
5.4 வேலை செய் (<i>vēlai sey</i>) — “to work”	23
5.5 Sentences about yourself	23
6 Dative Case and Dative Subjects	25
6.1 -ukku	25
6.2 peyar + ukku	26
6.3 enakkut tamil teriyum	27
6.4 எனக்கு / ஸ்கு / ஸ்நீ / ஸ்நிக்	28
7 Numbers One to Ten	31
7.1 ஒன்று இரண்டு மூன்று நான்கு ஐந்து	31
7.2 இரண்டு மூன்று நான்கு ஐந்து	32
7.3 ஆறு ஏழு எட்டு ஒன்பது பத்து	33
7.4 ஆறு ஏழு பத்து	34
8 Please	37
8.1 தயவுசெய்து	37
8.2 தயவுசெய்து / -உங்கள்	38
9 Sorry	41
9.1 மன்னிக்கவும்	41
9.2 மன்னிக்கவும் / sorry	43
10 Days of the Week	45
10.1 திங்கள்-ஞாயிறு	45
11 Colours	49
11.1 கருப்பு வெள்ளை சிவப்பு நீலம்	49

12 Family	51
12.1 அப்பா அம்மா அண்ணன் தம்பி அக்கா தங்கை	51
13 Body Parts	53
13.1 தலை கை	53
14 Seasons	55
14.1 வசந்த காலம் கோடைக் காலம் மழைக் காலம் குளிர் காலம்	55
15 Water and Rice	57
15.1 தண்ணீர் அரிசி சாதம்	57
16 Tamil Months	59
16.1 சித்திரை வைகாசி ஆனி ஆடி ஆவணி புரட்டாசி ஐப்பசி கார்த்திகை மார்கழி தை மாசி பங்குனி	59
17 Noon and Midnight	61
17.1 நண்பகல் நள்ளிரவு	61
17.2 நடுப்பகல், நடு இரவு	62
18 Telling Time	65
18.1 மணி	65
18.2 மணி / மணி	66
19 Asking Someone's Age	69
19.1 உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது?	69
19.2 உன் வயசு என்ன? / உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது?	70
20 Numbers Eleven to Twenty and Weather	71
20.1 பதினொன்று — இருபது	71
20.2 வானிலை	72
21 Dog and Cat	75
21.1 நாய், பூனை	75
22 Green and Yellow	77
22.1 பச்சை, மஞ்சள்	77

23 Day	79
23.1 நாள்	79
23.2 நாள் / தினம்	80
24 Night	83
24.1 இரவு	83
24.2 இரவு / ராத்திரி / இருள்	84
25 Good Night	87
25.1 இனிய இரவு	87
25.2 நல்ல இரவு / இரவு வணக்கம்	88
26 Morning	91
26.1 காலை	91
27 Evening	93
27.1 மாலை	93
28 Afternoon	95
28.1 பிற்பகல்	95
28.2 நடுப்பகல் / மதியம்	96
29 Good Morning	99
29.1 காலை வணக்கம்	99
30 Good Evening	101
30.1 மாலை வணக்கம்	101
31 Good Afternoon	103
31.1 மதிய வணக்கம்	103
31.2 மதிய	104
32 The Core Verbs	107
32.1 iru	107
32.2 pō	108
32.3 vā	110
32.4 sāppiḍu	111
32.5 pār	113
32.6 teri	114
The Tamil script (reference)	117

Chapter 1

Greetings

The Tamil greetings and the words that oil a first conversation — and, taught through them, how to read the Tamil script and how Tamil sits inside the Dravidian family. Each lesson introduces the letters its word needs, so you learn to read the word and understand it at once. *Practice lessons: lessons/TA-C01-*.md.*

1.1 வணக்கம் (*vaṇakkam*) — “greetings,” a small act of respect

The letters in this word

Tamil reads **left to right**, and every consonant carries a built-in “a.” வ va, க ka, ம ma. ண is a **retroflex** *ṇ* (tongue curled back). The dot on top — a **pulli** — *kills* the built-in vowel: க் is a bare *k*, so க்க is a held “kk.” Read வ·ண·க்·க·ம் → *vaṇakkam*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

வணக்கம் (*vaṇakkam*) comes from the verb வணங்கு (*vaṇaṅku*), “to bow, to pay homage.” Turned into a noun of the action, it means “a bowing, an act of reverence” — the idea of *namaste*, but from a **native Tamil** root, not a Sanskrit one. That is Tamil’s whole personality: an old language that keeps its home-grown words where its neighbours borrowed.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Watch “hello” split the family — four borrowed Sanskrit, Tamil alone kept its own:

Language	“Hello”	Source
Tamil	வணக்கம் <i>vaṇakkam</i>	native Dravidian
Kannada	<i>namaskāra</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Malayalam	<i>namaskāram</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>namaste</i>	Sanskrit
English	<i>hello</i>	Germanic

Why it’s said this way

Said with the palms pressed together and a small bow — the gesture *is* the word. It serves as both **hello** and **goodbye**, any time, to almost anyone, respectful without being stiff.

1.2 நன்றி (*nanri*) — “thank you”

The letters in this word

New: ந *na* (**dental**, tongue on the teeth), ன *n* (**alveolar**, on the ridge behind the teeth, with a pulli), and ற *ra*. The vowel sign ி makes “i” (றி = *ri*). Read ந·ன·றி → *nanri*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நன்றி (*nanri*) grows from the root நல் (*nal*), “good” — so it literally means “**goodness**.” To thank, in Tamil, is to name the good someone did you.

Grammar Lens

Tamil hears three of every *n*, *l*, and *r*. You have now met ந (dental *n*), ன (alveolar *n*), and ண (retroflex *n*) — three letters for three tongue positions (on the teeth / on the ridge / curled back). Tamil does the same for *l* (ல ள ழ) and *r* (ர ற ள). English fuses each set into one letter;

Tamil keeps them apart, and the differences *change meaning*. Learn them word by word, not as a chart.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Thanks”	Note
Tamil	நன்றி <i>nanri</i>	native (<i>nal</i> , “good”)
Malayalam	<i>nandi</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian word
Kannada	<i>dhanyavāda</i>	Sanskrit
Telugu	<i>dhanyavādamulu</i>	Sanskrit
Hindi	<i>dhanyavād / shukriyā</i>	Sanskrit / Perso-Arabic

Malayalam, Tamil’s closest sister, kept the native word; Kannada and Telugu took the Sanskrit one — the family splits as it did over “hello.”

1.3 ஆம் (ām) — “yes”

The letters in this word

ஆ is the **independent vowel** “ā”: when a word *starts* with a vowel, Tamil uses a full vowel letter, not the little sign it hooks onto a consonant. ம் is a bare *m* (pulli). Read ஆம் → ām.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

ஆம் (ām) is the plain “yes.” Doubled for emphasis it becomes ஆமாம் (āmām), “yes, indeed.”

Grammar Lens

Tamil often says “yes” by **echoing the verb**: asked *vandāyā?* (“did you come?”), a natural yes is *vandēn* (“I came”). Bank *ām* as the simple word, but expect a “yes” to come back as a whole verb.

1.4 இல்லை (*illai*) — “no,” and how Tamil says a thing is *not*

The letters in this word

இ is the independent vowel “i” (word-initial, like ஆ). ல் is a bare *l* (pulli); லை is *lai* (the consonant ல with the vowel sign ை for “ai”). Read இ·ல்·லை → *illai*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

இல்லை (*illai*) is built on இல் (*il*), “not-being, absence” — so it is not really the adjective “no” but the statement “[it] is not, [there] is not.” Its positive twin is உண்டு (*undu*), “there is.”

Grammar Lens

Tamil negates by *being*, not with a “not”-word. Where English inserts *not/no*, Tamil swaps in the negative verb of existence: *puttakam undu* (“there *is* a book”) → *puttakam illai* (“there *is not* a book”). So *illai* is both the everyday “no” and the word that makes a whole sentence negative — a deeply Dravidian habit, unlike English or Hindi.

1.5 சரி (*sari*) — “okay,” the word that oils every conversation

The letters in this word

ச is one letter doing the work of English *s*, *ch*, and *j* — Tamil gives voicing no separate letters, so **position** decides the sound (just as க can be *k*, *g*, or *h*). ரி is *ri*. Read ச·ரி → *sari*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

சரி (*sari*) is native Tamil for “correct, even, level,” and so “okay, agreed.” It is the verbal nod of the language: propose a plan, hear a warm *sari*; doubled, *sari sari* = “alright, alright.”

Grammar Lens

One letter, several sounds. For its stop-consonants Tamil writes *one* letter per mouth-position and lets rules of position fill in the voicing (*k/g*, *s/ch*). The payoff is a strikingly *small* alphabet; the price is that the exact sound isn’t always predictable from the letter alone — you pick it up by ear, word by word.

1.6 Recap, and how Tamil says goodbye

Read		Meaning
வணக்கம்	<i>vaṇakkam</i>	hello / greetings
நன்றி	<i>nanri</i>	thank you
ஆம்	<i>ām</i>	yes
இல்லை	<i>illai</i>	no / there isn’t
சரி	<i>sari</i>	okay / correct

Why it’s said this way

Why Tamil won’t just say “I’m leaving.” The everyday goodbye is போய் வருகிறேன் (*pōy varugirēn*) — literally “I’ll go and come [back],” and the reply is போய் வா (*pōy vā*), “go, and come back.” A bare “I go” sounds like a final parting, so you always promise a return. A whole worldview folded into a farewell. (Or simply say *vaṇakkam* again — it parts as well as it meets.)

Next chapter: introducing yourself — *en peyar...* (“my name...”) — and Tamil’s *nī* / *nīṅgaḷ* (familiar / respectful “you”).

Chapter 2

Introducing Yourself

Now a first real exchange — giving your name, asking for someone else’s, and saying you’re glad to meet them:

என் பெயர் அருண். (*en peyar Arun* — “My name is Arun.”)
உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? (*uṅgaḷ peyar enna* — “What is your name?”)

Built the same way as the greetings — each piece taken apart, its letters and its root, then assembled. And here the roots run *native*: this is where Tamil is most itself. *Practice lessons: lessons/TA-C02-*.md.*

2.1 பெயர் (*peyar*) — “name,” and where the family is *not* Indo-European

The letters in this word

ப (*pa*) + ெ (the *e*-sign, written before, read after) → பெ (*pe*); ய (*ya*); ர் (bare *r*, with the pulli). Read பெ·ய·ர் → *peyar*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பெயர் (*peyar*, “name”) is **native Dravidian**, from Proto-Dravidian **peyar* / **pēr* — and it is *not* related to the Sanskrit *nāma* (Hindi *nām*, English *name*). Here the two great families part: where Indo-European shares one word for “name” from Ireland to North India, the Dravidian south kept its own. That is the whole reason to learn Tamil deeply — it preserves a word-stock older than the Sanskrit layer.

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“Name”	Source
Tamil	பெயர் <i>peyar</i>	native Dravidian (*peyar)
Malayalam	<i>pēr</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Telugu	<i>pēru</i>	the <i>same</i> Dravidian root
Kannada	<i>hesaru</i>	Dravidian (*pesar, with p→h)
Hindi	<i>nām</i>	Sanskrit <i>nāman</i> (Indo-European)
English	<i>name</i>	Indo-European

Four Dravidian tongues share *peyar/pēru*; only the Indo-European languages have *name/nām*.

2.2 என் (*en*) — “my”

The letters in this word

எ (independent vowel *e*, word-initial) + ன் (bare alveolar *n*, pulli) → *en*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

என் (*en*, “my”) is the possessive of நான் (*nān*, “I”) — native Dravidian, from the pronoun stem *yān / *nān. It has *no* Indo-European cousin: the Tamil “I/my” is built on a different root from the English *I* / *my* (which go back to *eǵ and *me-). Two families, two entirely separate words for the self.

2.3 என் பெயர் ... (*en peyar ...*) — “my name is...,” with no “is”

என் (my) + பெயர் (name) + name = **en peyar ...** *En peyar Arun.* = “My name is Arun.”

Grammar Lens

Tamil has no word for “is” here. Notice what’s missing: there is *no* verb. Tamil simply places “my name” beside “Arun” — *en peyar Arun*

— and the “is” is understood. This is the **zero copula**: for equational sentences (X is Y), Dravidian needs no “to be” at all, where English needs *is*, Hindi needs *hai*, and Arabic (you’ll see) also drops it. Tamil says only “my name Arun.”

2.4 நீ / நீங்கள் (*nī* / *nīṅgaḷ*) — “you,” familiar and respectful

The letters in this word

நீ: ந (dental *na*) + ீ (the long-ī sign) → *nī*. நீங்கள் addsங்கள் (*ṅgaḷ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நீ (*nī*, familiar “you”) ← Proto-Dravidian **nīn* — native, unrelated to the European “you” words (which come from **tū*). நீங்கள் (*nīṅgaḷ*) is *nī* + the plural ending *-kaḷ*.

Grammar Lens

Respect by the plural — again. Tamil grades “you” in two: *nī* (familiar — friends, children) and *nīṅgaḷ* (respectful — and literally the *plural*, “you-all”). This is the *same* politeness-by-plural you would find in French *vous* — address one respected person as “you all.” For a first meeting, always *nīṅgaḷ*.

2.5 என்ன (*enna*) — “what”

The letters in this word

எ (*e*) + ன் (bare *n*) + ன (*na*) → *enna* — a doubled, held *nn*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

என்ன (*enna*, “what”) is native Dravidian, on the interrogative stem **yā-* / **e-* that heads Tamil’s whole question family: *enna* (what), *yār*

(who), *eppo* (when), *enge* (where), *ēn* (why). Like Hindi’s *k*- words and English’s *wh*- words — but from a *different* root, the Dravidian one.

2.6 உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? (*uṅgaḷ peyar enna*) — “what’s your name?”

உங்கள் (*uṅgaḷ*, “your”) is the possessive of *nīṅgaḷ* (“you,” respectful). So உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன? is literally “**your name what?**” — and again *no “is”*: the zero copula holds for questions too. Just three words, no verb.

Grammar Lens

Answer with the sentence you built: *En peyar Arun*. The familiar version swaps *uṅgaḷ* for *un* (“your,” from *nī*): *un peyar enna*?

2.7 மகிழ்ச்சி (*magilcci*) — “joy,” and “pleased to meet you”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The warm close is உங்களை சந்தித்ததில் மகிழ்ச்சி (*uṅgaḷai sandit-tatil magilcci*) — “**in having met you, joy.**” The key word மகிழ்ச்சி (*magilcci*, “joy, gladness”) is native Dravidian, from *magil* (“to rejoice”). It carries the ழ (*ḷ*) — a sound almost unique to Tamil, a retroflex glide with no English equivalent. (In casual speech Tamils often just smile, or say the English “nice to meet you.”)

2.8 The whole exchange

Tamil		English
என் பெயர் மீரா.	<i>en peyar Mira</i>	My name is Mira.
உங்கள் பெயர் என்ன?	<i>uṅgaḷ peyar enna</i>	What’s your name?
என் பெயர் அருண்.	<i>en peyar Arun</i>	My name is Arun.
மகிழ்ச்சி.	<i>magilcci</i>	Pleased to meet you.

Every atom native and traced: *peyar* (Dravidian *peyar, *not name*), *en* (from *nān*, “I”), *enna* (Dravidian question-stem). And the Tamil habit to keep: the **zero copula** — an equational sentence needs no “is” at all. Next chapter: *eppadi irukkīṅgal?* (“how are you?”) and answering with *nallā* — the responding cycle.

Chapter 3

How Are You?

After the name comes the exchange everyone actually has — and, for the first time, Tamil reaches for a verb “to be”:

நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்? (*nīṅgaḷ eppaṭi irukkiṟīrgaḷ* — “How are you?”)
நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன். (*nāṇ nalamāga irukkiṟēṇ* — “I’m well.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/TA-C03-.md.*

3.1 எப்படி (*eppaṭi*) — “how,” another of the e-questions

The letters in this word

எ (*e*) + ப்ப (*ppa*) + டி (*ṭi*) → எப்படி (*eppaṭi*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

எப்படி (*eppaṭi*, “how”) is native Dravidian — the interrogative base எ (*e-*) + *paṭi* (“manner”), “in what manner.” Tamil’s questions nearly all begin with this **e-**: *eṇṇa* (what), *eppaṭi* (how), *eppōdu* (when), *eṅḡē* (where), *ēṇ* (why). Where Hindi gathers questions under *k-* and English under *wh-*, Tamil gathers its own under **e-** — a separate, older family.

3.2 நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்? — “how are you?”

The new word is இருக்கிறீர்கள் (*irukkīrīrgal*): the verb stem இரு (*iru*, “to be, exist, stay”) + present + ீர்கள் (*-īrgal*, “you,” respectful). The verb comes last, as always.

Grammar Lens

Now the copula returns. Chapter 2 showed Tamil drops “is” for *equations* (*eṇ peyar Arun*, “my name Arun”). But “how are you?” is about a *state* — how you *exist* — and for that Tamil does use a verb, இரு (*iru*). So: no verb for “my name is Arun,” a real verb for “how are you.” The ending *-īrgal* already means “you (respectful),” so *nāṅgal* can be dropped.

3.3 நான் (*nāṇ*) — “I,” the Dravidian first person

The letters in this word

ந (dental *na*) + ா (long *ā*) + ன் (*ṇ*) → நான் (*nāṇ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நான் (*nāṇ*, “I”) ← Proto-Dravidian **yāṇ* / **nāṇ* — native, and (unlike Hindi’s *main*, cousin of English *me*) **not** related to the European “I/me” family. Its possessive is the என் (*eṇ*, “my”) you already met: *nāṇ* “I,” *eṇ* “my.” Tamil’s “I” is a clear marker that Dravidian grew up apart from the Indo-European world around it.

3.4 நலம் (*nalam*) — “well,” and how to answer

The letters in this word

ந (*na*) + ல (*la*) + ம் (*m*) → நலம்.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நலம் (*nalam*, “wellness, welfare”) is native Dravidian, from நல் (*nal-*, “good”) — the root behind நல்ல (*nalla*, “good”) and நன்றி (*naṇṇi*, “thanks,” literally “goodness,” from Chapter 1). So “thank you” and “I’m well” share a root: both are *nal-*, “good.”

Assemble: நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன் (*nāṇ nalamāga irukkīrēṇ*) — “I am well” (*nalam* + *-āga* “in a ... way” + *iru* + “I”). Casually: *nallā irukkēṇ*.

3.5 பரவாயில்லை (*paravāyillai*) — “no problem”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பரவாயில்லை literally “**there is no harm**” — *paravāy* (“harm”) + இல்லை (*illai*, “is-not”). It serves as “it’s okay / no worries / you’re welcome.” The atom இல்லை (*illai*), from Chapter 1, is the Tamil “is-not,” the mirror of *iru* (“is”). It is shared, almost unchanged, across Tamil, Kannada, and Malayalam (*illa*) — a deep Dravidian bond; only Telugu breaks away to *lēdu*.

Grammar Lens

Illai negates existence and equations alike: *nāṇ illai* (“it’s not me”), *paṇam illai* (“there’s no money”), and, alone, plain “no.” Hold *iru* / *illai* together — “is” and “is-not.”

3.6 The whole exchange

Tamil	English
நீங்கள் எப்படி இருக்கிறீர்கள்?	How are you?
நான் நலமாக இருக்கிறேன், நன்றி.	I’m well, thank you.
பரவாயில்லை.	No problem / you’re welcome.

Every atom traced: *eppaṭi* (the native *e-* questions), *nāṇ* (Proto-Dravidian, unrelated to *me*), *nalam* (*nal-* “good,” the root of *naṇṇi*), and

the *iru* / *illai* pair — “is” and “is-not.” Next chapter: the farewells — and Tamil never says a plain “goodbye.”

Chapter 4

Farewells

Tamil does not say a plain “goodbye.” It says something warmer, and stranger to English ears — “I’ll go and *come back*”:

போய் வருகிறேன். (*pōy varugirēṇ* — “I’ll go and come back.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/TA-C04-.md.*

4.1 போ (*pō*) — “go,” and வா (*come*)

The letters in this word

ப (*pa*) + ோ (long *ō*) → போ (*pō*). Its partner வா (*vā*, “come”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

போ (*pō*, “go”) and வா (*vā*, “come”) are native Dravidian verbs of the deepest layer — single syllables, whole words on their own: *pō!* (“go!”), *vā!* (“come!”). You need both, because Tamil’s goodbye is “I go, and I *come back*.”

4.2 போய் வருகிறேன் (*pōy varugirēṇ*) — “I’ll go and come back”

போய் (*pōy*, “having gone”) + வருகிறேன் (*varugirēṇ*, “I come”) — literally “**having gone, I come**,” i.e. “I’ll go and come back.” A Tamil speaker never signs off with a bare “I’m leaving” — it sounds final, ill-omened. The reply is warm: போய் வா (*pōy vā*, “go and come [back]”).

Across the family — the same idea, five ways

Language	“go and come back” (goodbye)
Tamil	<i>pōy varugirēṇ</i>
Kannada	<i>hōgi baruttēne</i>
Telugu	<i>velli vastānu</i>
Malayalam	<i>pōyi varāṇ</i>
Bengali (Indo-Aryan)	<i>āshi</i> (“I come”)
Hindi (Indo-Aryan)	<i>phir milenge</i> (“we’ll meet again”)

The whole subcontinent, Dravidian and Indo-Aryan alike, prefers a promise of return to a blunt farewell.

Grammar Lens

The “having ...d” participle. *Pōy* chains actions: “having gone, (then) I come.” Tamil strings verbs like beads — all but the last in a participle form, the last fully conjugated.

4.3 நாளை பார்க்கலாம் (*nālai pārkkalām*) — “see you tomorrow”

The letters in this word

நாளை (*nālai*): நா (*nā*) + னை (*lai*, retroflex ள *ḷ*). பார்க்கலாம் (*pārkkalām*) = பார் (*pār* “see”) + *-kkalām* (“let’s / we may”).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நாளை (*nālai*, “tomorrow”) is native, from நாள் (*nāl*, “day”). பார் (*pār*, “to see”); so the phrase is “tomorrow, let’s see [each other].” Note the retroflex ள (*ḷ*), tongue-tip curled up and back — a sound English lacks.

4.4 மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் (*mīṇṭum sandippōm*) — “we’ll meet again”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம் = மீண்டும் (*mīṇṭum*, “again”) + சந்திப்போம் (*sandippōm*, “we will meet”). Two vocabularies in two words: *mīṇṭum* is **native Dravidian** (from *mīl*, “to return”); சந்தி (*sandi*, “to meet”) is a **Sanskrit** loan — from *sandhi* (“a joining”), the very term Sanskrit grammar uses for how sounds join at a boundary. A Dravidian core beside a Sanskrit borrowing — the recurring thread of this track.

4.5 The farewells

Tamil	English
போய் வருகிறேன்.	I’ll go and come back. (goodbye)
போய் வா.	Go and come back. (the reply)
நாளை பார்க்கலாம்.	See you tomorrow.
மீண்டும் சந்திப்போம்.	We’ll meet again.

Roots banked: *pō/vā* (the oldest verbs), *nāl* (“day” inside “tomorrow”), and *mīṇṭum* (native) beside *sandi* (Sanskrit). Next chapter: the first real verbs — *nāṇ tamīl pēsugirēṇ* — and Tamil’s sentences begin to move.

Chapter 5

The First Verbs

Until now, “to be” and “to be-not.” Now verbs that *act* — and Tamil’s sentences begin to move:

நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன். (*nāṇ tamiz pēsugirēṇ* — “I speak Tamil.”)

Practice lessons: lessons/TA-C05-.md.*

5.1 பேசு (*pēsu*) — “to speak,” your first full verb

The letters in this word

ப (*pa*) + ே (long *ē*) + சு (*su*) → பேசு (*pēsu*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பேசு (*pēsu*, “to speak”) is native Dravidian; the bare stem is also the command “speak!” To say “I speak,” Tamil stacks two endings on the stem — **tense** then **person**:

pēsu- (speak) + *-gir-* (present) + *-ēṇ* (“I”) → பேசுகிறேன்
(*pēsugirēṇ*), “I speak.”

The *-ēṇ* ending is “I,” so the word *nāṇ* is rarely needed. Change the ending, change the person: *pēsugirāṇ* (he), *pēsugirāl* (she), *pēsugirārgal* (they / you-respectful).

Grammar Lens

Stem + tense + person. Every Tamil verb is built this way — a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, glued in that order. Learn the pattern once and every verb follows it.

5.2 நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் — “I speak Tamil”

நான் (I) + தமிழ் (*tamiḷ*, “Tamil,” the object) + பேசுகிறேன் (speak) — “I Tamil speak,” verb last. The name தமிழ் (*tamiḷ*) ends in the famous ழ (*ḷ*), a curled retroflex between “r,” “l,” and “zh” found in almost no other language — Tamil is sometimes called “the *ḷ* language.” It names one of the oldest living literary tongues on earth, its poetry two thousand years old and still read.

Grammar Lens

No gender on “I speak.” *Pēsugirēṇ* is the same whether a man or a woman says it — Tamil marks **no gender in the first or second person** (only the third: *-āṇ* he / *-āl* she). This is unlike Hindi, where even “I speak” changes for the speaker’s gender (*boltā/boltī*). Tamil saves gender for “he/she/it.”

5.3 வாழ் (*vāḷ*) — “to live, to flourish”**The letters in this word**

வா (*vā*) + ழ (*ḷ*, the retroflex from *tamiḷ*) → வாழ் (*vāḷ*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

வாழ் (*vāḷ*, “to live, flourish, thrive”) is native, warmer than a plain “reside.” From it: வாழ்க்கை (*vāḷkkai*, “life”) and the blessing வாழ்க (*vāḷga*, “may you live / long live”), as in *vāḷga tamiḷ*. “I live” = நான் வாழ்கிறேன் (*nāṇ vāḷgirēṇ*) — the same stem + present + “I” as *pēsugirēṇ*.

5.4 வேலை செய் (*vēlai sey*) — “to work”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

செய் (*sey*, “to do, make”) is a core native verb, and Tamil — like Hindi with *karnā* — builds compounds by putting a noun in front of it: வேலை செய் (*vēlai sey*, “work-do” = “to work”), *samaiyal sey* (“to cook”), *udavi sey* (“to help”). So “I work” is நான் வேலை செய்கிறேன் (*nāṇ vēlai seygiṟēṇ*).

Grammar Lens

Noun + செய் = a new verb — the exact twin of Hindi’s “noun + *karnā*” (*kām karnā*). Two unrelated families, Dravidian and Indo-Aryan, hit on the same trick: an all-purpose “do” verb with nouns bolted on. Millennia side by side, Tamil and Hindi quietly traded habits like this.

5.5 Sentences about yourself

Tamil	English
நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன்.	I speak Tamil.
நான் சென்னையில் வாழ்கிறேன்.	I live in Chennai.
நான் வேலை செய்கிறேன்.	I work.

Three verbs, one engine: a stem, a tense-marker, a person-ending, the verb always last — and no gender in the first person. Roots banked: *pēsu* (speak), *vāl* (live → *vālkkai* “life,” *vālga* “long live”), *sey* (do → *vēlai sey* “to work,” the twin of Hindi’s *karnā*), and *tamiḷ* itself, with its signature retroflex *ḷ*. From here, Tamil’s sentences only grow.

Chapter 6

Dative Case and Dative Subjects

6.1 -உக்கு (-ukku) — “to, for”

Your first **case ending**. English says “**to** me” with a separate word in front. Tamil says it with a piece **stuck on the back** — and that small difference is the biggest structural fact about the language.

Grammar Lens: Adding it on

Take a noun you know and add -உக்கு:

word	+ the dative	meaning
பெயர் <i>peyar</i> — name	பெயருக்கு <i>peyarukku</i>	to/for the name
வேலை <i>vēlai</i> — work	வேலைக்கு <i>vēlaiukku</i>	for work

The suffix has two shapes — -உக்கு *-ukku* and -க்கு *-kku* — chosen by the sound the noun ends in. One case, two forms; the seam still shows. And with “I” — this one is irregular and worth memorising, because you’ll use it constantly:

நான் *nān* (“I”) → எனக்கு *enakku* (“to me”)

The pronoun changes its body (*nān* → *en-*) before the suffix lands. Nouns don’t — they just take the ending.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*peyar ... peyarukku*”
- “*nān ... enakku*” — “I” ... “to me”
- “*vēlaiikku*” — “for work,” from Ch. 5’s வேலை

Before you move on

What does **-உக்கு** mean? (“**To**” or “**for**.”) Where does it go? (**On the end** of the noun — Tamil adds, it doesn’t put a word in front.) What is “to me”? (**எனக்கு** *enakku* — the pronoun’s body changes to *en-* first.) Why does the suffix show up as *-ukku* and *-kku*? (**One case, two shapes**, chosen by the noun’s ending.) Next: compare that visible one-purpose suffix with a fused Latin ending.

6.2 -உக்கு — one carriage in a suffix train

You can point to *peyar* and *-ukku* separately. That visible seam is the structural lesson.

Grammar Lens: Stacking versus fusion

	Tamil -ukku	Latin -īs
fixes the case?	dative , always	dative or ablative
carries number?	no; another suffix can	plural is baked in
carries declension?	no	first/second class is baked in
visible seam?	peyar + ukku	one fused ending

Tamil **stacks**. Each suffix contributes one meaning in a fixed order, like a train carriage. Latin **fuses** case, number, and class into an indivisible ending, and *-īs* does not even identify one case by itself.

This is **agglutinative** structure: long words remain buildable because their pieces stay legible. The comparison is not about simplicity; it is about where the grammatical information lives.

Your turn

- *Break apart*: *peyar + ukku*
- *Say it*: “one suffix, one meaning, visible seam”

- *Contrast:* Tamil stacks · Latin fuses

Before you move on

What does *-ukku* contribute? (**Dative to/for**, one meaning.) What does Latin *-is* fuse? (**Case, plural number, and declension class.**) Which system leaves the seam visible? (**Tamil's agglutinative stack.**)

6.3 எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும் — “I know Tamil”

In Chapter 5 you said நான் தமிழ் பேசுகிறேன் — “I speak Tamil,” with *nān* as the subject. Now say “I **know** Tamil.” Tamil will not let you use *nān*.

You’ll want to know: The sentence

எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும். *enakku tamil teriyum*. literally: “**to-me** Tamil is-known.”

Word by word:

piece

எனக்குத் <i>enakku(t)</i>	“to me” — the dative from the last lesson
தமிழ் <i>tamil</i>	Tamil (Ch. 5)
தெரியும் <i>teriyum</i>	“is known / is apparent”

That extra **த்** on *enakku* is **sandhi** — a joining consonant Tamil inserts between certain words to smooth the seam. It belongs to neither word on its own; it exists only because they are next to each other. Nothing to learn yet, but worth noticing, because you will see it constantly.

You are not the subject. *Nān* is gone — the person has been moved into the dative. What’s left in the plain, unmarked form is *tamil*: the sentence is now about **the language**, and you are merely the one it is known **to**.

(Grammarians call *enakku* the **dative subject**, because it behaves like the subject even though it isn’t in the subject case. The odd feeling of the sentence is exactly that split.)

Grammar Lens: Why: things that happen *to* you

Tamil sorts verbs by whether you **do** something or something **happens to** you. Speaking is something you do — so Ch. 5 used *nān*. But knowing, liking, wanting, being hungry, being cold: these arrive at you. Tamil marks that by putting the person in the **dative**.

English frames it as	Tamil frames it as
I know Tamil	Tamil is known to me
I like it	it is pleasing to me
I am cold	cold is to me

English does this occasionally and archaically — “**methinks**” is exactly it (*me* is dative: “it seems **to me**”). Tamil made it a rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*enakku tamil teriyum*”
- the contrast — “*nān tamil pēsugirēn*” (I speak) ... “*enakku tamil teriyum*” (known to me)
- the literal — “to-me Tamil is-known”

Before you move on

What does எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும் literally say? (“**To-me** Tamil **is-known**.”) Which word has English got that Tamil hasn’t? (A nominative “**I**” — *nān* is replaced by the dative *enakku*.) Why does Tamil use the dative here? (Because knowing **happens to** you; you don’t **do** it.) Which English word preserves the same idea? (**Methinks** — “it seems **to me**”.) Next: watch all four Dravidian sisters use the same experiencer shape.

6.4 -ukku, -ku, -ge, -ikku — the family shows its bones

Tamil says knowing happens **to** you. Its three closest sisters make the same grammatical choice.

Grammar Lens: Four sentences, one construction

language	“I know [the language]”	dative
Tamil	<i>enakku tamil teriyum</i>	-ukku
Telugu	<i>nāku telugu vaccu</i>	-ku
Kannada	<i>nanage kannada gottu</i>	-ge
Malayalam	<i>enikku malayālam ariyām</i>	-ikku

The verbs differ, but the experiencer sits in a dative whose forms visibly belong together: *-ukku* / *-ku* / *-ge* / *-ikku*. This is family evidence, just as *blanc/bianco/branco* exposes Romance kinship.

The comparison also makes cross-language practice useful: once you recognize “to me,” you can search for the known or apparent thing rather than forcing an English subject onto the sentence.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “-ukku · -ku · -ge · -ikku”
- *Point to*: the experiencer in each sentence
- *Put it another way*: “the language is known to me”

Before you move on

Do the four sisters agree on dative experiencers? (**Yes.**) Which four suffix shapes reveal the relationship? (**-ukku, -ku, -ge, -ikku.**) What stays plain in the sentence? (The thing **known or experienced.**)

Chapter 7

Numbers One to Ten

7.1 ஒன்று, இரண்டு, மூன்று, நான்கு, ஐந்து — one to five

Five words — and the same point *vaṇakkam* made, told again in numbers: Tamil counts with **its own** words, not borrowed ones.

You'll want to know: The five

	numeral	word	said
1	௧	ஒன்று	<i>onru</i>
2	௨	இரண்டு	<i>iraṇṭu</i>
3	௩	மூன்று	<i>mūnru</i>
4	௪	நான்கு	<i>nāṅku</i>
5	௫	ஐந்து	<i>aintu</i>

Two writing systems sit side by side here: the **word** (spelled out in letters) and the **numeral** (a single symbol — ௧ ௨ ௩ ௪ ௫, Tamil's own digits, as distinct from 1 2 3 4 5 as they are from Roman I II III). You'll meet the digits again whenever a price or a page number is written in Tamil.

If you're doing the writing track, you can already read pieces of these: ந and ன (the *n*-family), ற the hard *r* inside *mūnru*, and the **pulli** dot that stacks ன்ற into the single cluster you hear in ஒன்று and மூன்று.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “onru, iraṇṭu, mūnru, nānṅku, aintu”

- read the digits aloud — க ௨ ௩ ௪ ௫

Before you move on

Count to five in Tamil. (*Onru*, *iraṇṭu*, *mūnru*, *nānku*, *aintu*.) Are Tamil’s numbers borrowed from Sanskrit, like Hindi’s? (**No** — they’re native Dravidian.) Which two writing systems sit side by side? (Spelled-out **words** and Tamil’s own **numerals**.) Next: compare these native forms across the family.

7.2 Two to five — one family in four regional coats

Hindi’s number forms are Sanskrit worn smooth. Tamil’s are native Dravidian, so their sister-language shapes reveal the family directly.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

	Tamil	Kannada	Telugu	Malayalam
2	<i>iraṇṭu</i>	<i>eraḍu</i>	<i>reṇḍu</i>	<i>raṇṭu</i>
3	<i>mūnru</i>	<i>mūru</i>	<i>mūḍu</i>	<i>mūnnu</i>
4	<i>nānku</i>	<i>nālku</i>	<i>nālugu</i>	<i>nālu</i>
5	<i>aintu</i>	<i>aidu</i>	<i>aidu</i>	<i>añcu</i>

Each row is one word in four regional coats. That shared skeleton is why one Dravidian language gives you a running start on another.

One is less tidy: Tamil *onru*, Kannada *ondu*, and Malayalam *onnu* share old *on-*, while Telugu uses the separate formation *okaṭi*. The family agrees more neatly on 2–5 than on 1.

The letters in this word

In *onru* and *mūnru*, **ன்ற** is alveolar *n* running into hard *r*, almost one knock: *on-ru*, *muun-ru*. Pulli on **ன்ற** removes its vowel before the cluster.

Your turn

- Say it: “iraṇṭu · eraḍu · reṇḍu · raṇṭu”
- Say it: *onru* and *mūnru*, holding **ன்ற** together

- *Identify:* Telugu *okaṭi* as the different “one”

Before you move on

Are these forms borrowed? (**No**, native Dravidian.) Which numbers stay tidiest across the family? (**Two through five**.) Which language forms “one” differently? (**Telugu**, *okaṭi*.)

7.3 ஆறு, ஏழு, எட்டு, ஒன்பது, பத்து — six to ten

Five more — and one of them is written with the single letter
Tamil is most proud of.

You’ll want to know: The five

	numeral	word	said
6	சு	ஆறு	<i>āru</i>
7	எ	ஏழு	<i>ēlu</i>
8	அ	எட்டு	<i>eṭṭu</i>
9	கூ	ஒன்பது	<i>onpatu</i>
10	ய	பத்து	<i>pattu</i>

You’ll want to know: Seven carries the letter that names the language

Look at ஏழு (*ēlu*, seven). Its middle letter is ழ — the retroflex approximant, the sound English can only clumsily spell *zh*. It is the rarest and most characteristic sound in Tamil, and it sits inside the language’s **own name**: *Tamil* (தமிழ்) ends in this very letter. So *seven* is a free daily rehearsal of the sound that says who the language is. Curl the tongue back, don’t touch, and voice it: *ē-lu*.

(You met its cousin ற — the hard *r* — back in ஆறு / *āru*, six. Tamil keeps these apart carefully: ஆறு *āru* and ஏழு *ēlu* end in two different sounds English would both call “r/zh”.)

Grammar Lens: Nine is built from words you already have

ஒன்பது (*onpatu*, nine) is not a fresh word to memorise — it is two you already know, joined:

ஒன் (*on-*, “one,” from last lesson) + பது (*patu*, “ten”) →
ஒன்பது = “one-to-ten” — one short of ten.

And ten itself is பத்து (*pattu*). Say *onpatu* then *pattu* and you can hear nine leaning on ten. That is a common Dravidian habit — nine described as one-away-from-ten rather than named outright.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “āru, ēlu, eṭṭu, onpatu, pattu”
- seven, feeling the ழ — “ēlu”, the sound in *Taml*
- nine taken apart — “on + patu → onpatu”, one short of ten
- read the digits — கூ ஏ அ கூ டி

Before you move on

Count six to ten in Tamil. (*Āru*, *ēlu*, *eṭṭu*, *onpatu*, *pattu*.) Which number is written with ழ, and where else does that letter appear? (**Seven**, *ēlu* — the same letter that ends *Taml*.) How is **nine** built? (*On* “one” + *patu* “ten” → *onpatu*, one short of ten.) Next: follow these forms across the family and hear Kannada *p* soften to *h*.

7.4 Six to ten — family resemblances and one Kannada shift

The Tamil forms are learned. Now use their sister shapes as evidence for inheritance and regular sound change.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Six and seven remain close: Tamil *āru*, Kannada *āru*, Malayalam *āru*; Tamil *ēlu*, Kannada *ēlu*, Malayalam *ēlu*. Tamil and Malayalam also keep eight and nine nearly identical: *eṭṭu* and *onpatu/onpatu*. Telugu wanders on eight and nine with *enimidi* and *tommidi*, so those forms are less reliable as family-wide recognition anchors.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil and Malayalam say **pattu**, while Kannada says **hattu**. The initial $p \rightarrow h$ is a regular Kannada shift, not a random replacement. Compare Tamil *pāl*, “milk,” with Kannada *hālu*.

A correspondence lets differences prove relationship: repeated p/h pairs are stronger evidence than one accidental resemblance.

Your turn

- Say it: Tamil *pattu* · Kannada *hattu*
- Say it: Tamil *pāl* · Kannada *hālu*
- Identify: *ēlu* / *ēḷu* / *ēlu* as one inherited seven

Before you move on

What happens to Tamil *pattu* in Kannada? (P regularly softens to **h**: *hattu*.) Which second pair confirms the pattern? (*Pāl* / *hālu*, “milk.”) Which language diverges most on eight and nine? (**Telugu**.)

Chapter 8

Please

8.1 தயவுசெய்து (tayavu seytu) — please (do the kindness)

Across a whole band of Asia, the word for *please* is really the word **compassion**, dressed as a small request. Tamil says it most literally of all: “**do** the kindness.”

You’ll want to know: The phrase

தயவுசெய்து = **please**, literally “**do the kindness / grace**.” It is two pieces snapped together:

- தயவு (*tayavu*) = **kindness, compassion, grace** — from Sanskrit **daya** “compassion.”
- செய்து (*seytu*) = “**having done**,” from the verb செய் (*sey*) “to do.”

So *tayavu seytu* is an invitation: *do me the kindness (of...)*. You place it in front of a request the way English puts “please” in front of one.

This is the same instinct as **Arabic** *min fadlik* (“from your **grace**”) and **Hindi** *krpayā* (from *krpā*, “**compassion**”). Naming the kindness you hope for is one of the great strategies of politeness — different from French’s “if it **pleases** you,” and from Latin/German’s “I **ask**.”

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

All four Dravidian cousins build *please* the very same way — **daya** plus a light verb “do / place / become”:

- Tamil தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu* — kindness + **do**
- Kannada ದಯವಿಟ್ಟು *dayaviṭṭu* — compassion + **having placed**
- Telugu దయచేసి *dayacēsi* — compassion + **having done**
- Malayalam ദയവായി *dayavāyi* — compassion + **as / having become**

One idea, four scripts. Learn one and you can almost read the others.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “tayavu” — the kindness — then “seytu,” having done
- the whole phrase — “tayavu seytu” = please, do the kindness

Before you move on

What is the Tamil phrase for please? (தயவுசெய்து *tayavu seytu*.) What do its two pieces mean? (“**Kindness**” *tayavu* + “**having done**” *seytu* — *do the kindness*.) Which languages ask the same way? (**Kannada**, **Telugu**, **Malayalam** with *daya*, and further off **Arabic** *faḍl* and **Hindi** *kṛpā*.) Next: decide when the standalone phrase is natural and when the verb carries the courtesy.

8.2 தயவுசெய்து or -உங்கள்? — politeness in phrase or verb

Tamil has a phrase meaning “do the kindness,” but everyday courtesy often sits somewhere English speakers do not expect: inside the verb.

Why it’s said this way

A standalone தயவுசெய்து is more emphatic and formal than English “please.” Ordinary polite commands use respectful -உங்கள் (*-uṅgaḷ*):

- உட்காருங்கள் *uṭkāruṅgaḷ* — please sit

- சொல்லுங்கள் *sollunga!* — please tell me

Use *tayavu seytu* to mark “please, do me the kindness” warmly or formally. Let the verb ending carry routine courtesy.

Script you’ll notice: Read the join in செய்து

செ is *ca* with the ெ sign for *e*. ய் is *ya* shut off by *pulli*, a bare *y*, before து *tu*. The same dot that built numbers now makes the consonant seam in *seytu* visible.

Your turn

- *Choose*: emphatic request → தயவுசெய்து
- *Choose*: ordinary “please sit” → உட்காருங்கள்
- *Break apart*: செ + ய் + து → செய்து

Before you move on

What carries everyday “please”? (The respectful verb ending - *unga!*.) When is *tayavu seytu* especially useful? (A **markedly polite or emphatic** request.) What silences *y* in ய்? (The **pulli**.)

Chapter 9

Sorry

9.1 மன்னிக்கவும் (mannikkavum) — please forgive

You already know தயவுசெய்து, “please.” Tamil’s “sorry” gives you something its Dravidian cousins don’t: a forgiveness-word that’s Tamil through and through, not borrowed from Sanskrit.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மன்னிக்கவும் is built from three pieces:

- மன்னி (*manni*) = “to forgive, excuse, pardon” — and unlike the words you’ll meet in Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam, this is Tamil’s **own** native verb, not borrowed from Sanskrit **kṣamā**.
- -க்க (*-kka*) = an infinitive-forming ending.
- -உம் (*-um*) = a formal, written-register particle used to make a soft, general request or permission — the same particle you’d see on a sign asking visitors to வரவும் (“please come” / “you may come”).

So மன்னிக்கவும் reads as something like “**may [one] forgive**” — a polite, slightly formal way of asking for forgiveness, more at home in writing or a considered apology than tossed off in passing.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Where Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam all reach for the Sanskrit noun **kṣamā** (“patience, forgiveness”) and turn it into a verb, **Tamil uses its own root**:

- Tamil மன்னிக்கவும் *mannikkavum* — from Tamil மன்னி *manni*
- Kannada ಕ್ಷಮಿಸಿ *kṣamisi* — from Sanskrit **kṣamā**
- Telugu క్షమించండి *kṣaminṇcaṇḍi* — from Sanskrit **kṣamā**
- Malayalam ക്ഷമിക്കണം *kṣamikkaṇam* — from Sanskrit **kṣamā**

Where “please” showed the whole family sharing one Sanskrit-derived idea (*daya*), “sorry” shows the opposite: Tamil kept its own word while its cousins borrowed the same Sanskrit one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “manni” — forgive — the Tamil root, not from Sanskrit
- the whole word — “mannikkavum” = please forgive
- contrast — Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam all use **kṣamā** instead

Before you move on

What does மன்னிக்கவும் mean, and what is it built from? (“**Please forgive**” — *manni* “to forgive” + *-kkavum*, a formal request ending.) What’s different about Tamil’s forgiveness-word compared to Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam? (**It’s Tamil’s own native root** — the other three borrow Sanskrit *kṣamā* instead.) Next: place the word in its real register and read the doubled alveolar n.

9.2 மன்னிக்கவும் — formal forgiveness and a doubled n

The root is native Tamil. Its everyday conversational fit is less simple than a one-to-one dictionary entry suggests.

Why it's said this way

மன்னிக்கவும் leans formal: a “please forgive” on a notice or in a considered apology. Spoken Tamil may use shorter regional forms or borrow English “sorry.” Colloquial variation is real, so treat formal/written as a reliable center, not a claim that one casual form covers every region.

Script you'll notice: Read ன்னி

In ன்னி, alveolar ன is first silenced by pulli and then repeated before the vowel. The spelling holds the consonant across the syllable boundary:

ன் + னி → ன்னி — *n-ni*

This is the same gemination-by-repetition principle used elsewhere in Tamil; the sound is doubled without inventing a new ligature.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “man-ni-kkavum,” holding both doubled consonants
- *Choose:* considered/formal apology → மன்னிக்கவும்
- *Qualify:* casual alternatives vary by region

Before you move on

What is the reliable register center of *mannikkavum*? (**Formal/written or considered apology.**) Must every region use it casually? (**No.**) How does ன்னி show a doubled *n*? (Pulli stops the first ன், then full னி follows.)

Chapter 10

Days of the Week

10.1 திங்கள்-ஞாயிறு — a home-grown and borrowed week

You’ve seen Hindi’s week built entirely from Sanskrit deity-names plus **वार** (*vār*). Tamil’s week tells a richer story: it uses its **own** word for “day,” and **some** of its planet-names are Tamil’s own too — while others are borrowed, just like Hindi’s.

Grammar Lens: The pattern: [planet] + கிழமை, “day”

Every Tamil weekday ends in **கிழமை** (*kizhamai*), “day” — a native Dravidian word, not the Sanskrit **வாரம்** (*vāram*) that Hindi, Kannada, and Telugu build on (though Tamil also keeps a more formal, Sanskritic *-vāram* set alongside this everyday one):

Tamil weekday	planet-word, meaning, and source
திங்கள்கிழமை	<i>thingal</i> , “ Moon ” — Tamil’s own word
செவ்வாய்க்கிழமை	<i>cevvāy</i> , traditionally “ the red one ” — likely Tamil’s own descriptive name
புதன்கிழமை	<i>pudhan</i> , Mercury — borrowed from Sanskrit Budha
வியாழக்கிழமை	<i>viyāzhan</i> , Jupiter — likely from Sanskrit, via a name for Bṛhaspati
வெள்ளிக்கிழமை	<i>velli</i> , traditionally “ silver ” — likely Tamil’s own descriptive name
சனிக்கிழமை	<i>san̄i</i> , Saturn — borrowed from Sanskrit Śani
ஞாயிற்றுக்கிழமை	<i>ñāyiru</i> , “ Sun ” — Tamil’s own word

Why it’s said this way

Notice the pattern: **Moon**, **Mars**, **Venus**, and **Sun** all carry Tamil’s own descriptive or native words, while **Mercury**, **Jupiter**, and **Saturn** carry Sanskrit ones. This isn’t Tamil “failing” to have its own full week — it’s a genuine **blend**, native Dravidian vocabulary standing right alongside Sanskrit loans, in the same list. (Note for the Tamil-speaking reviewer: this lesson spells Monday திங்கள்கிழமை, the common form — the more traditional sandhi-shifted spelling திங்கட்கிழமை may be preferred and should be swapped in on review if so. The *cevvāy* “red one” and *viyāzhan* Jupiter-name derivations in particular are worth treating as the traditional, commonly-given account rather than settled certainty — exact planet-name histories this old are not always fully nailed down.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “thingal” — moon, Tamil’s own word — then “kizhamai,” day
- the borrowed ones — “pudhan, viyāzhan, sani” — Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn from Sanskrit
- the native ones — “thingal, cevvaḃ, velli, ṇāyiru” — moon, Mars, Venus, sun

Before you move on

What does every Tamil weekday end in, and where does that word come from? (கிழமை *kizhamai*, “day” — Tamil’s **own** word, not Sanskrit *vāra*.) Which four planet-names are Tamil’s own, and which three are Sanskrit borrowings? (**Moon, Mars, Venus, Sun are native; Mercury, Jupiter, Saturn are Sanskrit** — *Budha, Brhaspati, Śani*.)

Chapter 11

Colours

11.1 கருப்பு, வெள்ளை, சிவப்பு, நீலம் — three of Tamil’s own, one borrowed

You’ve already seen Tamil mix native and Sanskrit words in its day-names. Colors tell a **cleaner** version of the same story: three colors are Tamil’s own, and the fourth is the one color that keeps showing up borrowed, in language after language.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- கருப்பு (*karuppu*) = “**black**” — native Tamil/Dravidian.
- வெள்ளை (*vellai*) = “**white**” — native Tamil/Dravidian, and built on the very same வெள் (*vel-*, “bright, silvery”) root you already met in வெள்ளி (*velli*), “Venus/silver,” from the days-of-the-week lesson.
- சிவப்பு (*sivappu*) = “**red**” — native Tamil/Dravidian.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நீலம் (*nīlam*) = “**blue**” — from **Sanskrit** नील (*nīla*), “dark blue,” the very same root behind Hindi’s नीला (*nīlā*). This *nīla* is also the name of the indigo plant and its dye — part of why blue dye is so historically linked to India — but be careful: the English word **indigo** itself is a *separate*, Greek-derived word (describing where the dye was imported *from*, not descended from *nīla* by sound change; see the Hindi color lesson for that careful distinction).

Why it's said this way

This isn't random. You may remember from Latin's color lesson that “**blue**” is, across many of the world's languages, one of the **last** basic colors to settle into its own fixed word — often arriving late, or borrowed, compared to black, white, and red. Tamil's colors look like exactly this pattern in miniature: three old, native words, and one — blue — reaching outside the language for a Sanskrit loan.

(Note for the Tamil-speaking reviewer: please confirm *karuppu*, *vellai*, *sivappu*, *nīlam* are the forms you'd teach first — regional/colloquial Tamil may prefer different everyday variants, and this lesson would benefit from your check the way the day-names lesson did.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the three native ones — “karuppu, vellai, sivappu” — black, white, red
- the borrowed one — “nīlam” — blue, from Sanskrit
- the echo — “vellai” and “velli” share the same vel- root

Before you move on

Which three Tamil colors are native, and which one is borrowed? (**Karuppu**, **vellai**, **sivappu** (black/white/red) are native; **nīlam** (blue) is a **Sanskrit** loan.) What root does *vellai* share with a word you already know? (**Vel-** “bright/silvery” — the same root as *velli*, “Venus/silver.”) Why might blue be the one borrowed color? (**Blue is often one of the last basic colors** to settle into a fixed word across many languages — the same pattern Latin's *caeruleus* showed.)

Chapter 12

Family

12.1 அப்பா, அம்மா, and four sibling words

You’ve learned Spanish *hermano* and *hermana*, plus French *frère* and *sœur* — one word each for “brother” and “sister.” Tamil asks a question those languages never do: **is this sibling older or younger than you?**

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

- அப்பா (*appā*) = “**father**”
- அம்மா (*ammā*) = “**mother**”

Both are native Dravidian words, of the same simple, worldwide “baby-talk” shape (a repeated consonant plus a vowel) found across unrelated language families everywhere — not borrowed from Sanskrit, not a coincidence with any one language in particular, just how small children’s mouths tend to form their first words for parents.

You’ll want to know: Siblings — split by age, not just gender

Here’s the real lesson: Tamil doesn’t have one word for “brother” and one for “sister.” It has **four**:

Tamil	meaning
அண்ணன் (<i>aṇṇan</i>)	older brother
தம்பி (<i>tambi</i>)	younger brother
அக்கா (<i>akkā</i>)	older sister
தங்கை (<i>tangai</i>)	younger sister

There is no single Tamil word that just means “brother” the way Spanish *hermano* does — you’re expected to know, and say, **whether they’re older or younger than you** every time you refer to a sibling. This isn’t a small detail: it reflects how central **relative age and seniority** are in South Asian family structure and address — the same instinct that makes “older sibling” versus “younger sibling” a live, spoken distinction, not just something you *could* mention if you wanted to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “appā, ammā” — father, mother
- the four siblings — “aṇṇan, tambi” (older/younger brother), “akkā, tangai” (older/younger sister)
- the key question — “older, or younger?” — before you can even say “brother” or “sister” in Tamil

Before you move on

How many Tamil words mean “brother” or “sister,” and why? (**Four** — அண்ணன்/தம்பி for older/younger brother, அக்கா/தங்கை for older/younger sister — Tamil requires knowing the sibling’s **age relative to you**.) Are அப்பா and அம்மா borrowed from Sanskrit? (**No** — native Dravidian baby-talk-type words, of a shape found across unrelated languages worldwide.)

Chapter 13

Body Parts

13.1 தலை, கை — head and hand, both Tamil’s own

You’ve seen Hindi’s *sir* and *hāth* trace all the way back to Sanskrit. Tamil’s words for the same two body parts tell a simpler story: **both are native**.

You’ll want to know: The words

- தலை (*talai*) = “**head**” — native Dravidian.
- கை (*kai*) = “**hand**” — native Dravidian.

Neither is borrowed from Sanskrit, unlike Hindi’s *sir* (< Sanskrit *śiras*) or *hāth* (< Sanskrit *hasta*). Tamil simply kept its own words for two of the most basic parts of the body.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “talai” — head
- “kai” — hand
- the contrast — Hindi borrowed these from Sanskrit; Tamil didn’t

Before you move on

What are Tamil's words for head and hand? (தலை *talai*, கை *kai*.)
Are either of these Sanskrit loans? (**No** — both native Dravidian,
unlike Hindi's Sanskrit-descended *sir* and *hāth*.)

Chapter 14

Seasons

14.1 வசந்த காலம், கோடை, மழை, குளிர் — the four words, and the real season underneath

Tamil has words that line up with Spanish’s four seasons — but, just like the Hindi lesson on ऋतु, forcing them into a clean four-way split hides what actually matters on the ground.

You’ll want to know: The four words

Tamil	meaning	source
வசந்த காலம் (<i>vasantha kaalam</i>)	“spring”	<i>vasantham</i> is a Sanskrit loan
கோடைக் காலம் (<i>kodai kaalam</i>)	“summer”	கோடை <i>kodai</i> is native Tamil for “heat”
மழைக் காலம் (<i>mazhai kaalam</i>)	“rainy season”	மழை <i>mazhai</i> , native Tamil for “rain”
குளிர் காலம் (<i>kulir kaalam</i>)	“winter/cold season”	குளிர் <i>kulir</i> , native Tamil for “cold”

Every one of these is built the same way: a word for the **feel** of the season (heat, rain, cold — or the borrowed *vasantham*) plus காலம் (*kaalam*), “**time/season**.” Be honest about *kaalam* itself, too: it’s ultimately from Sanskrit काल (*kāla*, “time”) — but it was assimilated into Tamil so long ago and so thoroughly that it functions as completely ordinary vocabulary today, quite unlike a fresh, still-foreign-feeling loan like *vasantham*.

Why it's said this way

Just as Hindi's traditional calendar makes the monsoon (*varṣā*) its own central season rather than a footnote, Tamil Nadu's actual climate is shaped far more by மழைக்காலம் (*mazhai kaalam*, “the rains”) than by any crisp four-way Western split. There's no dramatic autumn leaf-fall in a tropical climate, and “spring” as a distinct, keenly-felt season is a much weaker idea here than in temperate Europe. The four words above are real and used — but the rains, not a European four-season year, are what actually organizes agricultural and everyday life across much of Tamil Nadu.

(Note for the Tamil-speaking reviewer: please check whether these are the words and register you'd teach first, and whether there's more to say about how Tamil Nadu's own seasonal year is actually divided in practice.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kodai” — heat/summer, native — then “kaalam,” time/season
- “mazhai kaalam” — the rains, the real central season
- “kulir kaalam” — the cold season
- the one loanword — “vasantha kaalam,” spring, from Sanskrit

Before you move on

Which of the four season-words is a Sanskrit loan, and which are native Tamil? (வசந்தம் *vasantham* is Sanskrit; கோடை, மழை, குளிர் are all native.) What season actually shapes life in Tamil Nadu the most, and why doesn't the four-season frame capture that? (மழைக்காலம், the **rains** — Tamil Nadu's tropical climate doesn't have a sharp four-way split the way temperate Europe does.)

Chapter 15

Water and Rice

15.1 தண்ணீர், அரிசி, சாதம் — water, and rice, the real staple

Every language so far in this arc taught “bread” as the staple food. Here, that would be **dishonest** — bread isn’t the everyday staple in Tamil food culture. **Rice** is, and it comes with one of the most famous (if contested) etymological journeys of any food-word.

You’ll want to know: தண்ணீர் — water, literally “cool water”

தண்ணீர் (*taṇṇīr*) = “**water**” — built from தண் (*taṇ*, “cool”) + நீர் (*nīr*, “**water**”). Everyday Tamil doesn’t just say “water” — it says, quite literally, “cool water.”

You’ll want to know: அரிசி and சாதம் — rice, raw and cooked

Tamil, like most of South India, distinguishes the **uncooked grain** from the **cooked dish** with two separate words, not one:

- அரிசி (*arisi*) = “**rice**” (the raw, husked grain) — native Dravidian.
- சாதம் (*sātam*) = “**cooked rice**” (the meal itself, what’s actually eaten) — likely Sanskrit-influenced. Tamil also keeps a native word for the same idea, சோறு (*cōru*) — the two sit side by side as everyday near-synonyms.

Why it's said this way

Here's the exciting part, held with appropriate care: many etymologists connect அரிசி (*arisi*) to the **English word “rice” itself** — the proposed chain runs Dravidian *arisi* → **Greek** *óryza* → Latin *oryza* → Old French *ris* → English **rice**. If true, English speakers have been saying a Dravidian word for centuries without knowing it. But be honest: standard etymological dictionaries mark Greek *óryza*'s origin as **genuinely uncertain** — a Dravidian source is one widely cited hypothesis among others (an Indo-Aryan *vr̥hi*-related source is also proposed), not a settled, universally agreed fact.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*taṇ*” — cool — then “*nīr*,” water — then “*taṇṇīr*,” cool water
- “*arisi*” — raw rice — then “*sātam*,” cooked rice
- the famous (contested) link — “*arisi*” → possibly English “rice”

Before you move on

What does தண்ணீர் literally mean? (“**Cool water**” — *taṇ* “cool” + *nīr* “water.”) What two words does Tamil use for rice, and why two? (அரிசி *arisi*, raw grain; சாதம் *sātam*, cooked rice — the raw grain and the cooked meal get separate words.) Is it certain that English “rice” comes from Tamil *arisi*? (**Not certain** — it's a widely cited hypothesis via Greek *óryza*, but that Greek word's origin is genuinely disputed among etymologists.)

Chapter 16

Tamil Months

16.1 சித்திரை to பங்குனி — Tamil’s own solar calendar

By now you’ve seen Arabic and Hindi each juggle two calendars. Tamil adds a **third distinct system** to the mix — one still actively used for Tamil New Year and Pongal, not a historical curiosity.

You’ll want to know: The twelve Tamil months

சித்திரை, வைகாசி, ஆனி, ஆடி, ஆவணி, புரட்டாசி, ஐப்பசி, கார்த்திகை, மார்கழி, தை, மாசி, பங்குனி (*Chithirai, Vaikāsi, Āni, Ādi, Āvaṇi, Purattāsi, Aippasi, Kārthigai, Mārgazhi, Thai, Māsi, Panguṇi*).

This is the **Tamil solar calendar** — a real, independent civil calendar, distinct from both the Gregorian calendar and the Hindu lunisolar (Vikram Samvat-style) calendar. Its months are traditionally tied to **nakshatras** (the 27 lunar-mansion star groups): each month is named for the nakshatra the **moon** sits near on the **full-moon (pournami) day** that falls within that month — the moon’s position, not the sun’s, and tied to that month’s full moon specifically, not simply the month’s start.

Why it’s said this way

You’ve now met three genuinely separate calendar traditions across this course: the Gregorian solar calendar (borrowed names, everyday civil use in most of the world), the pan-Indian Hindu lunisolar calendar (Chaitra, Vaishākh... tied to the six *ṛtu*), and now Tamil’s **own** solar calendar, following neither. சித்திரை 1 (the 1st of Chithirai) is **Tamil New**

Year; **தை 1** (the 1st of Thai) is **Pongal**, one of Tamil Nadu’s most important harvest festivals. These dates are fixed by the Tamil solar calendar, and only shift slightly against the Gregorian calendar (rather than drifting widely, the way lunar/lunisolar festival dates do) because it’s solar too — just a different solar calendar, starting its year at a different point and naming its months differently.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the twelve — “Chithirai, Vaikāsi, Āṇi, Āḍi, Āvaṇi, Puraṭṭāsi, Aippasi, Kārthigai, Mārgazhi, Thai, Māsi, Panguṇi”
- “Chithirai 1” — Tamil New Year
- “Thai 1” — Pongal

Before you move on

What kind of calendar is the Tamil month system — solar, lunar, or lunisolar? (**Solar** — a genuinely separate calendar from both Gregorian and Hindu lunisolar.) What are the twelve months traditionally named for? (**Nakshatras**, lunar-mansion star groups.) What two important occasions are dated by this calendar? (**Tamil New Year** (Chithirai 1) and **Pongal** (Thai 1).)

Chapter 17

Noon and Midnight

17.1 நண்பகல், நள்ளிரவு — one old “middle” root, two survival stories

You’ve just watched Kannada and Telugu each reach for Sanskrit’s *madhya* to name noon. Tamil doesn’t reach for Sanskrit at all here — it reaches into its own, much older layer of vocabulary instead.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Both of today’s words trace back to the same root: நள் (*naḷ*), a **Proto-Dravidian** word for “**middle, centre**” — a genuine synonym of the everyday நடு (*naṭu*, “middle”) you already know, just from an older layer of the vocabulary. நள் didn’t disappear from Tamil; it survives today mainly in **literary/poetic** compounds — நள்ளிருள் (*naḷḷirul*, “thick darkness”) and நள்ளென் கங்குல் (*naḷḷen kaṅkul*, “deep night”) — rather than in everyday colloquial speech.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நள்ளிரவு (*naḷḷiravu*) = “**midnight**” = நள் (*naḷ*, “middle”) + இரவு (*iravu*, “**night**,” a word every Tamil speaker still uses on its own) — நள் shows up here exactly as you’d expect. நண்பகல் (*naṇpakal*) = “**noon, midday**” traces to the **same** நள் root, fused with பகல் (*pakal*, “**daytime**”) — but here it surfaces as நண்- rather than நள்-, a sandhi-driven surface change before the following ப. Same root, two different faces, depending on what it’s fused to.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “naḷ” — an old word for “middle” — then “naḷḷiravu,” midnight
- “naṇṇapakal” — noon, the same naḷ root, resurfacing as naṇ-

Before you move on

What old Proto-Dravidian root do நண்பகல் and நள்ளிரவு both trace back to, and what does it mean? (நள் *naḷ*, “middle” — surviving mainly in literary compounds like *naḷḷirul*, “thick darkness.”) Why does it surface as **naṇ-** in *naṇṇapakal*? (A sandhi change before following **p**.) Does Tamil reach for Sanskrit here? (**No**.) Next: meet the transparent *naṭu* synonyms Tamil kept beside these older compounds.

17.2 நடுப்பகல் and நடு இரவு — the transparent twins

Naṇṇapakal and *naḷḷiravu* preserve an older middle-root in fused forms. Tamil also kept versions whose pieces remain obvious today.

You’ll want to know: The living synonyms

- நடுப்பகல் (*naṭuppakal*) — “middle-daytime,” a dictionary synonym of *naṇṇapakal*
- நடு இரவு (*naṭu iravu*) — “middle night,” the transparent synonym of *naḷḷiravu*

Both use நடு (*naṭu*, “middle”), the everyday word still heard in *naṭuvē*, “in the middle.”

Latin daughter languages often inherit one fate for an old compound: eroded or transparent. Tamil kept **both fates inside one language**—old fused forms and fresh transparent synonyms side by side.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “naṇpakal · naṭuppakal” — two noon forms
- *Say it:* “naḷḷiravu · naṭu iravu” — two midnight forms
- *Point to:* *naṭu* as the visible everyday “middle”

Before you move on

Which everyday word builds the transparent forms? (நடு, *naṭu*, “middle.”) What did Tamil keep simultaneously? (**Older fused compounds and transparent synonyms.**) Are any pieces Sanskrit loans? (**No.**)

Chapter 18

Telling Time

18.1 மணி — Tamil’s native “bell,” and a real homophone trap

You’ve just watched Kannada and Telugu both borrow Sanskrit’s “bell” word for “hour,” matching Hindi exactly. Tamil goes its own way again here — with a genuinely tricky twist along the way.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மணி (*maṇi*) = “hour, o’clock” — and it also means “bell, gong,” the same double duty you’ve now seen several times. Wiktionary’s Tamil entry gives this *maṇi* its **own etymology**, separate from a Sanskrit-loan entry of the same spelling — most likely a **native Dravidian** word, not the Sanskrit घण्टा (*ghaṇṭā*) behind Kannada’s *gaṇṭe*, Telugu’s *gaṇṭa*, and Hindi’s *ghaṇṭā*. On this account, Tamil underwent the **same** “a bell announces the hour, so the bell-word becomes the hour-word” shift on its own, from a different starting point — though even the comparative Dravidian dictionary (DEDR) flags a possible Sanskrit connection for this whole word-family as unresolved, so hold “native” as the best current account rather than a settled fact.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “maṇi” — hour, also “bell” — native, NOT from Sanskrit *ghaṇṭā*

Before you move on

Is Tamil’s மணி (“hour”) from the same Sanskrit root as Kannada/Telugu/Hindi’s hour-words? (**Most likely no** — it’s treated as a native Dravidian “bell” word that independently reached “hour” the same way, though even DEDR flags this as not fully settled.) What semantic path links the meanings? (A **bell announces the hour**.) Next: distinguish the likely Sanskrit gem homophone and tell the time.

18.2 மணி — hour or jewel? Context decides

The likely native bell/hour word shares its spelling and sound with a clear Sanskrit loan meaning something entirely different.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil dictionaries list a second மணி from Sanskrit मणि (*maṇi*), “gem, jewel.” On that analysis, bell/hour and gem are **homophones**: one likely native, one borrowed, identical on the page. Context separates clock time from a jewel or personal name.

Malayalam dictionaries analyze their cognate differently, treating bell/hour and gem as one Sanskrit-derived word. Closely related languages do not always settle the same etymological question in the same way.

Grammar Lens: Tell the time

ஒரு மணி. — one o’clock, literally “one hour/bell”

>

இரண்டு மணி. — two o’clock

The number comes first; *maṇi* supplies the clock unit.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “oru maṇi” — one o’clock
- *Say it*: “iraṇṭu maṇi” — two o’clock

- *Choose by context:* clock → hour · jewelry/name → gem

Before you move on

What is the homophone trap? (A likely separate Sanskrit-borrowed **மணி** means **gem**.) Does Malayalam analyze the same forms identically? (**No.**) How do you say two o'clock? (இரண்டு மணி, *irantū maṇi*.)

Chapter 19

Asking Someone's Age

19.1 உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது? — Tamil actually has BOTH shapes

Same Sanskrit word one more time — but be careful here: Tamil isn't locked into just one of the two grammatical shapes you've now seen. It has both, in different registers.

You'll want to know: வயது — the same Sanskrit “vigor/age” word, a fourth time

வயது (*vayathu*) = “age” — the same Sanskrit वयस् (*vayas*, “age, vigor,” PIE cousin of Latin *vīs*) you've now met four times across Kannada, Telugu, Malayalam, and Tamil. All four Dravidian languages borrowed this exact Sanskrit word for “age” — none of them built a native alternative for this particular concept, unlike some others you've seen in this course.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “vayathu” — age
- *Connect:* Sanskrit *vayas* · Tamil *vayathu* · Latin *vīs*

Before you move on

Is Tamil's வயது the same Sanskrit word borrowed by all four Dravidian languages here? (**Yes** — none built a native alternative for this concept.) What did *vayas* originally include besides age? (**Vigor**.) Next: choose between Tamil's casual possessive and formal dative-plus-become shapes.

19.2 Your age what? / To you how many years becomes?

Tamil did not choose one age construction. Register selects between two shapes already visible elsewhere in the family.

Grammar Lens: Casual possessive

உன் வயசு என்ன? — “your age what?”

Casual speech uses a plain possessive with no dative and no verb, like Kannada and Telugu.

Grammar Lens: Formal dative plus “become”

உனக்கு எத்தனை வயது ஆகிறது? — “to you how many years is becoming?”

>

எனக்கு இருபது வயது ஆகிறது. — “to me twenty years is becoming.”

Formal/written Tamil uses the dative experiencer plus ஆகிறது (*aakirathu*, “is becoming,” from *aaku*). Malayalam uses a similar dative shape but chooses “exists” instead.

Do not compress these into “Tamil’s one grammar.” Both live in the language; setting and register choose between them.

Your turn

- *Say it*: “un vayasu enna?” — casual
- *Say it*: “unakku ettanai vayathu aakirathu?” — formal
- *Answer*: “enakku irupathu vayathu aakirathu”

Before you move on

Which shape is casual? (**Possessive**: “your age what?”) Which is formal? (**Dative** + **aakirathu**, “become.”) Does Malayalam use the same verb? (**No** — it uses “exists.”)

Chapter 20

Numbers Eleven to Twenty and Weather

20.1 பதினொன்று-இருபது — shared Dravidian patterns

Here’s how this arc closes: four completely different approaches to “twenty” across Sanskrit, Latin, Arabic — and then all four Dravidian languages quietly agreeing on the exact same compositional idea.

You’ll want to know: பதினொன்று-பத்தொன்பது — “ten” + digit

Tamil’s teens echo பத்து (*pathu*, “ten”) plus each digit — பதினொன்று (*patinondru*, 11), பன்னிரண்டு (*pannirandu*, 12), and onward through பத்தொன்பது (*pattonbatu*, 19) — the same digit-plus- ten-echo compounding you’ve now seen across Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam.

You’ll want to know: இருபது — transparently “two-tens”

இருபது (*irupathu*, “twenty”) = இரு (*iru*, an older word for “two,” alongside the everyday இரண்டு *irandu*) + பத்து (*pathu*, “ten”) — fully transparent as “two-tens,” matching Malayalam’s own *irupathu* almost letter-for-letter.

Why it's said this way

This closes the numbers arc with a genuinely clean pattern. Every Dravidian language in this course builds “twenty” the **same** compositional way — some (Tamil, Malayalam) keeping it fully transparent on the surface today, some (Kannada) with the same compositional origin but no longer visibly matching the modern standalone words for “two” and “ten,” some (Telugu) worn down further but most likely from the same root. Compare that to the other three families you’ve met: Sanskrit’s *विंशति* (*vimshati*), Latin’s *vīgintī*, and Arabic’s *عشرون* (*‘ishrūn*) are each their **own** special, non-compositional word for twenty — none built transparently from “two” and “ten” the way every single Dravidian language in this course does.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “patinondru, panniraṇḍu” — 11, 12
- “iru” — an older word for two, “pathu” — ten
- “irupathu” — twenty, “two-tens,” transparent

Before you move on

What two pieces build இருபது (twenty)? (இரு “two” + பத்து “ten” — “**two-tens**.”) Do all four Dravidian languages in this course build “twenty” the same compositional way? (**Yes** — Tamil and Malayalam keep it fully transparent today; Kannada shares the same compositional origin but its modern “two”/“ten” words no longer visibly match; Telugu’s is worn down further but most likely the same root.) Do Sanskrit, Latin, or Arabic build their word for twenty this way? (**No** — each has its own special, non-compositional standalone word instead.)

20.2 வானிலை — “the standing of the sky,” most likely all native

You’ve now seen a Persian+Sanskrit hybrid (Kannada), a pure Sanskrit compound (Telugu), and a Sanskrit compound echoing

“time” (Malayalam). Tamil most likely breaks the pattern one more time — with a word built entirely from native pieces.

You’ll want to know: வானிலை — vaanam + nilai

வானிலை (*vānilai*) = “**weather**” — built from:

- வானம் (*vānam*, “**sky**”) — most likely a **native Dravidian** word, with confirmed cognates in **Kannada** ಬಾನು (*bānu*, “sky”) and **Telugu** వాన (*vāna*, “rain,” from the same sky/rain-cloud root) — distinct from the Sanskrit sky word *ākāśa* that those same two languages use elsewhere.
- நிலை (*nilai*, “**state, standing, condition**”) — from நில் (*nil*, “**to stand**”), one of Tamil’s most basic native verb roots.

So *vānilai* literally means “**the standing of the sky**” or “**the sky’s state**” — and unlike its three Dravidian cousins, neither piece here is a Sanskrit or Persian/Arabic loan. (Treat “native” as the best current account rather than a fully settled fact, the same hedge you’ve seen elsewhere in this course — but both pieces are independently well-attested as old, native Dravidian vocabulary.)

You’ll want to know: மழை பெய்கிறது — “rain is falling”

மழை பெய்கிறது. — “It’s raining.” — literally “**rain is falling**.” (*mazhai peykiRathu* — from பெய் *pey*, “to fall/pour,” specifically used for rain.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “vānilai” — weather, “the standing of the sky”
- “vānam” — sky, “nilai” — state, from “nil,” to stand
- “mazhai peykiRathu” — it’s raining, “rain is falling”

Before you move on

What are the two pieces of வானிலை, and what does the whole word literally mean? (வானம், “sky,” + நிலை, “state/standing” — “**the standing of the sky**.”) Is either piece a Sanskrit or Persian/Arabic loan, unlike Kannada, Telugu, or Malayalam’s weather words? (**Most likely not** — both pieces are native Dravidian.) What Tamil word does Malayalam’s *mazha* match for “rain”? (மழை, *mazhai*.)

Chapter 21

Dog and Cat

21.1 நாய், பூனை — solid ground to close the arc, and an honest three-way split

This whole ANIMALS arc kept finding mystery dog-words — Spanish’s *perro*, English’s *dog*, Hindi’s *kuttā*, each one an unsolved puzzle displacing an older, expected word. Tamil’s dog-word closes the arc on the complete opposite footing: total, undisputed solid ground.

You’ll want to know: நாய் — no mystery, anywhere

நாய் (*nāy*, “dog”) is a solid, native **Proto-Dravidian** root — the exact same one behind Kannada’s ನಾಯಿ (*nāyi*) and Malayalam’s നായ (*nāya*). There is no debate about its origin, no substrate mystery, nothing like the *perro/dog/kuttā* pattern that ran through Spanish, English, and Hindi. Three unrelated language families each lost their expected word for “dog” to an unexplained newcomer — and right here, in the Dravidian family, the expected word simply **survived**, plainly and solidly, across (at least) three of its languages.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

பூனை (*pūnai*, “cat”) is Tamil’s own everyday word, matching Malayalam’s പൂച്ച (*pūcha*) closely — but be honest that “cat” splits Dravidian in a way “dog” doesn’t. Kannada’s everyday word, ಬೆಕ್ಕು (*bekku*), comes from a **different** ancient root (related to the word for “wildcat”); Telugu’s, పిల్లి (*pilli*), comes from yet **another** separate Proto-Dravidian root, most likely the very source behind Sanskrit’s *bidāla* and Hindi’s

billi. Tamil itself even keeps **rarer, alternate** cat-words — பில்லி and வெருகு — cognate with Telugu’s and Kannada’s everyday choices respectively, showing that all three roots were once available across the family; each language just settled on a different one as its everyday word.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāy” — dog, solid native Dravidian, no mystery anywhere
- “pūnai” — cat, Tamil’s everyday word, matching Malayalam
- the honest split — Kannada’s *bekku* and Telugu’s *pilli* come from two other, separate ancient roots

Before you move on

Is நாய் a mystery word, like Spanish’s *perro*, English’s *dog*, or Hindi’s *kuttā*? (**No** — a solid, undisputed native Dravidian root, shared with Kannada and Malayalam.) Does புனை share a root with Kannada’s *bekku* or Telugu’s *pilli*? (**No** — all three are genuinely separate ancient Dravidian roots; Tamil even keeps rarer alternate cat-words, *pilli* and *veruku*, echoing both of them.) Which Dravidian cat-word is most likely the source of Sanskrit’s *biḍāla* and Hindi’s *billi*? (**Telugu’s pilli.**)

Chapter 22

Green and Yellow

22.1 பச்சை, மஞ்சள் — closing the Dravidian arc, holding both patterns at once

You’ve now seen three different Dravidian answers to “how do green and yellow relate”: Kannada split them apart, Telugu fused them into one root, Malayalam kept them as two separate native words. Tamil, it turns out, quietly contains a trace of **both** of the last two patterns.

You’ll want to know: பச்சை — the familiar pan-Dravidian green

பச்சை (*paccai*, “green”) ← **Proto-Dravidian** **pac-* — the same root you’ve now met four times: Kannada’s *hasiru*, Telugu’s *pacca*, Malayalam’s *paccha*, and now Tamil’s own *paccai*.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மஞ்சள் (*mañcaḷ*, “yellow, turmeric”) is Tamil’s actual, everyday word for yellow — and it comes from a **completely separate** native Dravidian root, matching Malayalam’s മഞ്ഞ/മഞ്ഞൾ (*mañña/maññaḷ*) closely. Like Malayalam’s pair, this root has no Sanskrit involvement — it sits alongside *paccai*, not descended from it.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The **Tamil Lexicon** also records பசுப்பு (*pacuppu*, “greenish yellow”) — a genuine **doublet** of *paccai* itself, from the same **pac-* root,

matching Telugu’s *pasupu* closely. Unlike Telugu, though, this doublet is **not** Tamil’s everyday word for yellow — that job belongs to *mañ-cal*; *pacuppu* survives mainly as a dictionary-recorded shade word. So Tamil, uniquely in this arc, holds a trace of **both** patterns at once: a *pac-* doublet sitting quietly in the dictionary (Telugu’s pattern), next to a separate, dominant root doing the everyday work (Malayalam’s pattern).

(Note for the Tamil-speaking reviewer: *pacuppu*’s everyday currency is the part I’m least certain of — please confirm whether it’s a word you’d recognize as “greenish yellow,” or whether it reads as archaic/purely literary in the Tamil you’d teach first.)

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “பச்சை” — green, the pan-Dravidian *pac-* word
- “மஞ்சள்” — yellow, Tamil’s real everyday word, a separate root
- “பசுப்பு” — a rarer doublet of *paccai*, echoing Telugu’s pattern

Before you move on

What is Tamil’s everyday word for yellow, and is it related to **paccai**? (மஞ்சள், *mañcal* — **no**, a completely separate native root, matching Malayalam’s *mañña/maññal*.) What rarer Tamil word **IS** a doublet of *paccai*, from the same *pac-* root? (பசுப்பு, *pacuppu*, “greenish yellow” — echoing Telugu’s *pacca/pasupu* pattern.) Does any one pattern hold across all the Dravidian languages in this arc? (**No** — Kannada splits native/loan, Telugu fuses one root, Malayalam keeps two separate roots, and Tamil turns out to hold traces of both Telugu’s and Malayalam’s patterns at once.)

Chapter 23

Day

23.1 நாள் (nāl) — “day,” the one this arc’s Dravidian languages didn’t lose

You’ve now seen three Dravidian languages reach for a loanword — Sanskrit, twice, and Persian once — to name their everyday word for “day.” Tamil doesn’t. This lesson is about the one that didn’t.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

நாள் (nāl) — “day” — is native **Dravidian**, from **Proto-Dravidian** **nāl*. You’ve already met it, hiding inside நாளை (*nālai*, “tomorrow,” Chapter 4). But here’s the honest headline of this lesson: நாள் isn’t a survivor clinging to one narrow sense the way some native words elsewhere in this arc have been — it is simply Tamil’s **plain, everyday, unmarked** word for counting a day, as ordinary as மூன்று நாள் (*mūṇṇu nāl*, “three days”).

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “nāl” — “day,” native Dravidian, already met inside “tomorrow”
- “mūṇṇu nāl” — three days

Before you move on

Where did you already meet நாள் before this lesson? (Inside நாளை, *nālai*, “tomorrow,” Chapter 4.) Is Tamil’s everyday day-word a loanword? (No — நாள் is native Dravidian.) Is it marginal or literary? (No — it is the plain everyday counting word.) Next: compare the other sisters’ borrowed day-words and Tamil’s formal *tinam*.

23.2 நாள் and தினம் — everyday native, formal borrowed

Nāl is plainly native and everyday. Put that lexical choice beside the other Dravidian tracks.

You’ll want to know: Four everyday day-words

- Kannada **dina** — Sanskrit tatsama
- Telugu **rōju** — Persian loan
- Malayalam **divasam** — Sanskrit tatsama
- Tamil **nāl** — native Dravidian

Tamil is the only one here whose unmarked everyday counting word remains native.

You’ll want to know: Tamil still has தினம்

தினம் (*tinam*) is the same Sanskrit *dina* as Kannada/Malayalam, ultimately from PIE *dyew-*, “shine,” also behind Latin *diēs*. Tamil assigns it formal and compound work: சுதந்திர தினம், “Independence Day,” and தினசரி, “daily.” Casual counting remains *nāl*.

The language did not reject the loan; it gave native and borrowed forms different jobs.

Your turn

- Say it: “mūnru nāl” — three days

- *Say it*: “sutantira tinam” — Independence Day
- *Sort*: everyday native · formal/compound Sanskrit

Before you move on

Which track alone keeps a native everyday day-word? (**Tamil**.)
Where does *tinam* appear? (**Formal compounds**.) Is it unrelated
to Kannada *dina*? (**No** — it is the same Sanskrit tatsama.)

Chapter 24

Night

24.1 இரவு (iravu) — “night,” and a register question worth a native speaker’s ear

Last lesson, Tamil’s native day-word had no real competition. This lesson’s honest twist, hedged carefully, is that “night” may not tell the same story — and this is exactly the kind of claim worth checking against your own ear, not just a dictionary’s.

You’ll want to know: இரவு — already standing on its own, inside “midnight”

இரவு (iravu) — “night” — is native **Dravidian**, from **Proto-Dravidian** **cira* (“darkness”). You’ve technically already met it standing fully on its own: Chapter 17, while explaining நள்ளிரவு (*nalliravu*, “midnight,” நள் + இரவு), noted directly that இரவு itself is a word every Tamil speaker still uses on its own. This lesson gives it its own full chapter.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Tamil also keeps ராத்திரி (*rāttiri*), a Sanskrit **tatsama** from रात्रि (*rātri*) — the same word already met, as a tatsama, in Kannada’s *ratri* and Telugu’s *ratri* (though those two lessons didn’t draw out its PIE ancestry). It traces to **Proto-Indo-European** **h₁reh₁-* (“to rest”), a **completely different** root from Latin *nox*’s **nók^wts* — the same specific comparison already drawn for Hindi’s *raat* and Malayalam’s *rāthri* earlier in this arc, now a third confirmation, same false-cognate pattern, same honest non-relationship to *nox*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “iravu” — “night,” native, already met inside *nalliravu*
- “rāttiri” — Sanskrit loan, same PIE *h₁reh₁-* already drawn for Hindi and Malayalam, *NOT* related to Latin *nox*

Before you move on

Where did you already meet இரவு before this lesson? (Inside நள்ளிரவு, *nalliravu*, “midnight,” Chapter 17.) Does ராத்திரி’s PIE root match Latin *nox*’s? (No — **h₁reh₁-* “to rest,” the same false-cognate pattern already drawn for Hindi and Malayalam earlier in this arc.) Next: treat the proposed register split as a hypothesis and keep “darkness” separate from “night.”

24.2 Night words — a register hypothesis and a semantic boundary

Iravu is native and *rāttiri* borrowed. That alone does not tell you which one conversational Tamil prefers.

Why it’s said this way

At least one dictionary says ராத்திரி is more common colloquially, implying native இரவு may lean literary/written. If accurate, this reverses the day story, where native *nāl* is uncontested everyday speech. But the evidence is limited and dictionary-level. Treat this as a prompt for a native speaker’s ear, not settled fact. Register judgments require real usage, region, and setting—not a purity assumption about native versus borrowed words.

You’ll want to know: Darkness is a different word

இருள் (*irul*) means **darkness**, from Proto-Dravidian *cirVl* and cognate with Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam forms. It is not *iravu* “night as a time period” and comes from a different reconstructed root despite the similar sound.

Your turn

- *Qualify*: “one source says *rāttiri* is more colloquial”
- *Ask*: compare that claim with native regional usage
- *Contrast*: *iravu* night · *irul* darkness

Before you move on

Is the *rāttiri* register claim settled? (**No** — limited sourcing, worth checking against native usage.) Is இருள் interchangeable with இரவு? (**No** — darkness versus a time period, from different roots.)

Chapter 25

Good Night

25.1 இனிய இரவு (*iniya iravu*) — “good night,” and Tamil breaking the pattern one more time

Four languages in this arc all reached for the same Sanskrit phrase to say “good night.” This lesson closes the arc with the one that didn’t — and it’s a pattern you’ve actually seen from Tamil before, all the way back in Chapter 1.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

இனிய இரவு (*iniya iravu*) — “good night” — literally “sweet, pleasant night.” இனிய (*iniya*, “sweet, pleasant, dear”) is native Dravidian, from Proto-Dravidian **in-* (“sweet”) — the same root behind இனிப்பு (*inippu*, “sweet, dessert”). Paired with இரவு (*iravu*, “night,” already met last lesson), the whole phrase is built from Tamil’s own word-stock, start to finish.

Why it’s said this way

Every other language in this arc’s GREETING-GOODNIGHT lesson reached for the **same** Sanskrit phrase: Hindi’s शुभ रात्रि, Kannada’s ಶುಭ ರಾತ್ರಿ, Telugu’s శుభ రాత్రి, Malayalam’s ശുഭ രാത്രി — all four built from the identical tatsama pair, *śubh* (“to be beautiful”) + *rātri* (“night”). Tamil’s standard phrase reaches for **none** of that — no *śubha*-descended “good night” turned up as a commonly used Tamil form in the phrase-book sources checked for this lesson. Instead, Tamil built its own phrase from its own vocabulary.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*iniya iravu*” — “good night,” literally “sweet night,” fully native
- the pattern it breaks — every other language this arc shares one Sanskrit *śubh(a) rātri* phrase; Tamil doesn’t

Before you move on

What does இனிய இரவு literally mean, and what root does இனிய come from? (“**Sweet/pleasant night**” — Proto-Dravidian *in-*, “sweet.”) Does Tamil’s “good night” share the same Sanskrit *śubha rātri* phrase as Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam? (**No** — no such form turned up in the sources checked for this lesson; Tamil’s standard phrase is fully native, breaking the pattern shared by all four other languages.) Next: connect that choice back to Chapter 1 and build two native alternatives.

25.2 நல்ல இரவு and இரவு வணக்கம் — old roots recombined

Tamil’s native “sweet night” repeats the lexical choice that opened the course: build greetings from its own roots rather than the shared Sanskrit formula.

You’ll want to know: The Chapter 1 echo

வணக்கம் comes from native *vaṇṇiku*, “bow,” while neighboring greetings use Sanskrit *namas-*. At the other end of the day, இனிய இரவு is native while the same neighbors share Sanskrit *śubha rātri*.

Tamil also keeps two transparent alternatives:

- நல்ல இரவு — “good night,” using *nalla*, from the **nal-** “good” root already inside *naḷam* and *naṇṇi*
- இரவு வணக்கம் — “night greetings,” especially for close friends/family, recombining two fully known words

The learner does not memorize isolated formulas; known roots generate options.

Your turn

- *Say it:* “nalla iravu” — good night
- *Say it:* “iravu vaṇakkam” — night greetings
- *Trace it:* *nal-* → *na^lam* / *naⁿri* / *nalla*

Before you move on

Which root builds நல்ல? (**Nal-**, good.) What two known words make இரவு வணக்கம்? (**Night + greetings.**) What lexical pattern connects Chapter 1 and this chapter? (**Tamil keeps native greeting roots where neighbors share Sanskrit formulas.**)

Chapter 26

Morning

26.1 காலை (kālai) — “morning,” an honestly uncertain etymology

Every other language in this arc had a confidently-sourced story for its “morning” word — Sanskrit, or clearly native. Tamil’s own word for morning is different: even Wiktionary itself isn’t sure where it comes from.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

காலை (kālai) — “**morning**” — has an etymology that Wiktionary itself only hedges at: “**possibly** from Sanskrit काल्य (*kālyā*).” That’s a real hedge from the source itself, not one this lesson is adding for caution’s sake. Complicating things further: the related word கால் (*kāl*) carries **six** entirely distinct etymologies in Tamil — “leg/foot,” “irrigation channel,” “forest,” “wind,” a Sanskrit-derived “time” sense, and a conjunction meaning “if, when” — and காலை may be an accusative-type form built on the “time” sense specifically, or may not be. Be honest: this is genuinely **less settled** than Kannada’s confidently-native morning word or Telugu’s confidently-Sanskrit one. Don’t manufacture certainty the primary source itself doesn’t have.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

Wiktionary does confirm one solid fact: பகல் (already met, Chapter 17, “**daytime**”) is listed as காலை’s **coordinate term** — the two words sit side by side in the same semantic field, whatever காலை’s deeper root turns out to be. And அதிகாலை (“**early dawn**”) is

confirmed, per the Tamil Lexicon, as a fully transparent compound: **ati-** (“excessive, very”) + காலை, glossed simply as “early dawn” by the Tamil Lexicon.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kālai” — “morning,” an honestly uncertain etymology
- the hedge itself — Wiktionary says “possibly” Sanskrit kālya, not a confident claim
- “atikaalai” — “early dawn,” a transparent ati- + kālai compound

Before you move on

Is காலை’s etymology as confidently sourced as Kannada’s or Telugu’s morning words? (**No** — Wiktionary itself only says “possibly” Sanskrit kālya; genuinely uncertain, not settled.) What coordinate term does Wiktionary list alongside காலை? (பகல், “daytime,” already met in Chapter 17.) What does அதிகாலை literally build on? (**ati-** (“very”) + காலை — a transparent compound for “early dawn.”)

Chapter 27

Evening

27.1 மாலை (mālai) — “evening,” and a garland that only looks like the same word

Last lesson’s morning word had an uncertain origin. This evening word is different — confidently native — but it comes with its own honest twist: it looks exactly like a completely unrelated word.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மாலை (mālai) — “evening” — happens to be spelled identically to another, completely **unrelated** Tamil word: மாலை meaning “garland, wreath, necklace.” Wiktionary treats these as **two separate etymologies**, not one word with two senses. The garland sense traces to Old Tamil and is compared to Sanskrit माला (mālā) — with a genuinely interesting note: it’s “**probably borrowed FROM Dravidian languages**” into Sanskrit, not the other way around. A rare reverse-direction loan, worth noticing against this whole project’s usual Sanskrit-into-Dravidian pattern.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The **evening** sense of மாலை is a **separate** Old Tamil word entirely, compared instead to மால் (māl) — which Wiktionary traces to **Proto-Dravidian** *mā/*māl, with senses including “கருமை” (“**blackness, darkness**”), plus archaic senses of “illusion, confusion” and, as a proper noun, the Hindu deity **Vishnu**. Be honest about the exact mechanism here: Wiktionary’s own etymology for “evening” only says “**compare**

māl” — it does **not** explicitly state that “evening” derives specifically from the **darkness** sense rather than some other sense of this multi-meaning root. The connection (evening = the time it grows dark) is natural and plausible, but not nailed down with full certainty by the source itself. What **IS** certain: this is confidently **native** Dravidian vocabulary, a genuine contrast with TA-C26’s uncertain காமலை.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mālai” — “evening,” confidently native Dravidian vocabulary
- the homonym twist — a completely separate word, mālai, means “garland,” probably borrowed INTO Sanskrit from Dravidian
- the honest hedge — “evening” plausibly connects to māl’s “darkness” sense, but Wiktionary doesn’t spell out that exact link

Before you move on

Are evening-mālai and garland-mālai the same word with two meanings? (**No** — Wiktionary treats them as two entirely separate etymologies; a genuine homonym, not one word stretched.) Which direction did the garland sense’s Sanskrit connection likely travel? (**Dravidian into Sanskrit** — a reverse-direction loan, per Wiktionary’s own “probably borrowed from Dravidian languages” note.) Is it fully certain that “evening” derives from māl’s “darkness” sense specifically? (**No** — plausible and natural, but Wiktionary only says “compare māl,” without spelling out that exact mechanism.)

Chapter 28

Afternoon

28.1 பிற்பகல் (pirpakal) — “afternoon,” a similar sandhi trick to நண்பகல்

You already met a sandhi-driven surface change in Chapter 17 — நள் resurfacing as நண். This lesson’s afternoon word does a similar kind of trick, with a different word — though be honest that the two changes aren’t identical.

You’ll want to know: பிற்பகல் — பின் (after) + பகல் (daytime), a similar sandhi story

பிற்பகல் (pirpakal) — “afternoon” — is a transparent compound: பின் (*pin*, “after”) plus பகல் (*pakal*, “daytime,” already met inside நண்பகல், TA-C17 — though be aware the பிற்பகல் Wiktionary page itself glosses பகல் as “noon” in its own etymology line, a small inconsistency across Wiktionary’s own entries, not something this lesson introduces). Here’s the familiar pattern: பின் doesn’t stay பின் in this compound — it surfaces as பிற்- before the following ப — a **similar** kind of consonant sandhi to the one already taught in Chapter 17, where நள் became நண் before its own following ப. Be honest, though: Wiktionary’s own etymology for பிற்பகல் doesn’t discuss this mechanism at all, and the two changes move in different phonetic directions (nasal→stop here, lateral→nasal there) — this is the lesson’s own observation, not a sourced equivalence. Wiktionary labels this word **formal register**.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*pirpakal*” — “afternoon,” *pin* (“after”) + *pakal* (“daytime”)
- the sandhi echo — *pin* surfaces as *pir-*, a similar kind of change to TA-C17’s *naḷ→naṇ*, though not phonetically identical

Before you move on

What does *பிற்பகல்* literally build from, and what sandhi change happens to the first piece? (*பின்* “after” + *பகல்* “daytime” — *பின்* surfaces as *பிற-*, a similar kind of sandhi to TA-C17’s *naḷ→naṇ*, though the two changes move in different phonetic directions, not identical mechanisms.) What register does the fetched page label? (**Formal.**) Next: inspect the real noon/afternoon boundary blur and the separate *matiyam* root.

28.2 Noon or afternoon? — let the sources keep their blur

Pirpakal transparently says after-daytime. Dictionaries still do not draw a perfectly hard semantic boundary around its synonyms.

You’ll want to know: *நடுப்பகல்* overlaps

Wiktionary’s *pirpakal* page lists *நடுப்பகல்* as an afternoon synonym, while the earlier noon lesson documents the same word as a synonym of *நண்பகல்*, “noon.” This is genuine noon/afternoon boundary blur, not an inconsistency to erase. Time-period categories can widen differently across speakers and sources.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மதியம் (*matiyam*) is a Sanskrit tatsama from *madhya*, “middle,” the same root used by Kannada and Telugu. The fetched entry gives it **noon**, a synonym of *nanpakal*, not a dedicated afternoon meaning. An initial search summary claimed *matiyam* once meant “moon,” but that claim is absent from the actual fetched page. It is therefore **not asserted**. Source inspection outranks a search snippet.

Your turn

- *Say it: natuppakal* can overlap noon and afternoon
- *Say it: matiyam* — Sanskrit *madhya*, “middle,” listed as noon
- *Label:* the moon claim unsupported

Before you move on

Does the source draw a hard noon/afternoon line? (**No.**) What is *matiyam*’s sourced root and sense? (Sanskrit *madhya*, “middle,” and **noon.**) Is “originally moon” confirmed? (**No.**)

Chapter 29

Good Morning

29.1 காலை வணக்கம் — “morning greetings”

Every other language in this arc built its “good morning” on a word meaning “good” or “auspicious.” Tamil does something completely different: it just puts its everyday greeting word after its word for “morning.”

You’ll want to know: காலை வணக்கம் — literally, “morning greetings”

காலை வணக்கம் (kālai vaṇakkam) — “good morning” — is confirmed, by two independently-fetched sources, as Tamil’s standard greeting for this time of day, used “**from sunrise until around 11 AM.**” It’s built from two words you already have: காலை (already met, Chapter 26, “morning”) plus வணக்கம் (already met, Chapter 1, “reverence, homage” — Tamil’s everyday word for “hello”). Literally: “morning salutations.”

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the honest structural surprise: Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam each build their morning greeting on a **śubha**-equivalent word (“good, auspicious”) plus a time-word. Tamil does something genuinely **different** — there’s no “good/auspicious” word here at all. It’s simply வணக்கம், Tamil’s own general greeting, specified with காலை in front of it to mean “morning” greetings specifically. Also be honest about a claim that didn’t hold up: an initial search summary suggested a Sanskrit-borrowed word, “suprabhatham,” serves as a ca-

sual alternative — but that claim appears on **neither** of the two pages actually fetched, so it’s deliberately **not** asserted here.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “kālai vaṇakkam” — “good morning,” literally “morning greetings”
- the honest structural surprise — no śubha-equivalent word here at all, unlike every other language in this arc
- the two pieces you already know — kālai (Chapter 26) + vaṇakkam (Chapter 1)

Before you move on

- What two known words build காலை வணக்கம்? (காலை, “morning” + வணக்கம், “reverence/hello.”)
- Does it follow the śubha-equivalent + time-word pattern used by Hindi, Kannada, Telugu, and Malayalam? (**No** — காலை simply specifies Tamil’s own general greeting, வணக்கம்.)
- Is “suprabhatham” confirmed as a casual alternative? (**No** — neither fetched source supports that claim, so this lesson does not assert it.)

Chapter 30

Good Evening

30.1 மாலை வணக்கம் — “evening greetings”

Last chapter’s morning greeting followed its own pattern. This lesson checks whether the evening greeting follows the same one — rather than assuming it automatically does.

You’ll want to know: மாலை வணக்கம் — the same compositional pattern, independently confirmed

மாலை வணக்கம் (*mālai vaṇakkam*) — “good evening” — is confirmed, by two independently-fetched sources, as a real, standard Tamil evening greeting, used roughly from **afternoon through nightfall** (the two sources give slightly different exact windows — “after noon through evening” versus “late afternoon until nightfall” — a small, unsurprising looseness, matching the noon/afternoon boundary-blur already seen in TA-C28). It’s built exactly the same way as TA-C29’s morning greeting: **மாலை** (already met, Chapter 27, “**evening**”) plus **வணக்கம்** (already met, Chapter 1, Tamil’s general greeting). Literally: “**evening salutations**.”

Why it’s said this way

Here’s the honest methodological point: just because TA-C29’s morning greeting followed the “time-word + vaṇakkam” pattern doesn’t mean this evening greeting was assumed to follow it automatically. This arc has repeatedly found that greeting formation doesn’t reliably generalize, even within the very same language — Malayalam’s own morning greeting broke from the *śubha*+time-word pattern its afternoon and evening greetings both share, so “the pattern probably repeats” was never a safe

assumption on its own. So this greeting was independently verified via direct fetch before confirming the pattern really does repeat here — and it does, cleanly: no śubha-equivalent word appears in Tamil’s evening greeting either, same as the morning one.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “mālai vaṇakkam” — “good evening,” literally “evening greetings”
- the two pieces you already know — mālai (Chapter 27) + vaṇakkam (Chapter 1)
- the honest methodological point — this pattern was re-verified, not assumed to carry over automatically

Before you move on

What two already-known words does மாலை வணக்கம் build from? (மாலை, “evening” + வணக்கம், “greetings.”) Was it assumed that the evening greeting would follow the same pattern as the morning one, or was it independently checked? (**Independently checked** — via direct fetch, not assumed, since this arc has learned that greeting patterns don’t reliably generalize.) Does மாலை வணக்கம் use a śubha-equivalent word, like Hindi/Kannada/Telugu/Malayalam’s evening greetings do? (**No** — same as Tamil’s morning greeting, no śubha-equivalent word appears here either.)

Chapter 31

Good Afternoon

31.1 மதிய வணக்கம் (matiya vaṇakkam) — a sourced afternoon greeting

You already know that Tamil’s noon and afternoon boundaries can blur. Now learn one afternoon greeting without pretending that all speakers or teaching sources divide the day in exactly the same way.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

மதிய வணக்கம் (matiya vaṇakkam) — “good afternoon” — is confirmed, by two independently-fetched sources, as Tamil’s afternoon greeting, used roughly “**noon to around 4 PM**.” A third source, already used for the morning and evening greetings, doesn’t list a distinct afternoon greeting at all — it only covers “before noon” and “after noon through evening,” implicitly treating those two as bookending the whole day. This is an honest extension of TA-C28’s own noon/afternoon boundary-blur into the greeting layer, not a new problem to worry about. Use மதிய வணக்கம் when that afternoon slot fits the people and setting around you. Treat “noon to 4” as a useful learning window, not as a universal clock rule.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “matiya vaṇakkam” — “good afternoon,” confirmed real, used roughly noon to 4 PM

- the honest qualification — one source does not teach a separate afternoon greeting at all

Before you move on

What is one sourced Tamil greeting for “good afternoon”? (மதிய வணக்கம், **matiya vaṇakkam**.) Do all three fetched sources agree on a distinct “afternoon” greeting slot? (**No** — two confirm மதிய வணக்கம் directly; a third doesn’t list a separate afternoon greeting at all, treating morning and evening as bookending the day.) What clock window is a useful guide rather than a universal rule? (**Roughly noon to 4 PM.**)

31.2 மதிய — the greeting takes a different root

You can now say மதிய வணக்கம். This final step explains why its first word is not the ordinary afternoon word பிற்பகல்.

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The greeting begins with மதிய (**matiya**). It is the adjectival form of மதியம் (**matiyam**), “noon.” That noun entered Tamil from Sanskrit **madhya**, “middle”: noon is the middle of the day.

The adjective மதிய can be glossed “of or pertaining to afternoon.” That lets Tamil build மதிய வணக்கம் even though the dedicated word you learned for “afternoon” was பிற்பகல், the native compound from **pin** (after) + **pakal** (daytime).

Keep the two paths separate:

- பிற்பகல்: after + daytime → afternoon
- மதிய வணக்கம்: middle/noon adjective + greeting → good afternoon

The time word and the greeting do not have to share a root. That is one more reason not to manufacture a greeting by translating its pieces from another language.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- matiyam — “noon,” ultimately from Sanskrit madhya, “middle”
- pirpakal — “afternoon,” built from “after” + “daytime”
- matiya vaṇakkam — the afternoon greeting, built on matiya

Before you move on

Does மதிய வணக்கம் begin with பிற்பகல்? (**No.**) What noun is மதிய related to? (மதியம், “**noon.**”) What older root lies behind it? (**Sanskrit madhya, “middle.”**) Why should you learn the whole greeting rather than construct it from the time word? (**Tamil uses a different root in the greeting.**)

Chapter 32

The Core Verbs

32.1 இரு (iru) — “to be,” and the machine inside every Tamil verb

Thirty-one chapters of words. Now the engine room. Tamil builds a verb the way you thread beads on a string, and this first verb carries the whole string.

You’ll want to know: இரு

இரு — *iru* — to be, to exist, to stay

It is native Dravidian, from an old root meaning “be, remain, stay put.” Kannada kept the very same word, ಇರು (*iru*), and Malayalam has ഇരിക്കുക (*irikkuka*); Telugu went its own way with ఉండు (*undu*).

Iru is about **existing** or **being somewhere**, not about linking two nouns. Tamil says “I am at home” with *iru*, and says “I am a teacher” with no verb at all, just the two words side by side.

Its everyday first-person form is இருக்கிறேன் (*irukkīrēn*), “I am.” You have already heard it: the question *eppaḍi irukkīrīrgaḷ?* — “how are you?” — is this verb wearing a different ending.

The letters in this word

இ (the standing vowel *i*) + ரு (*ru*) → இரு. Both shapes turned up in இரவு (*iravu*, “night”).

In *irukkīrēn* the க்ക is held long — *i-ruk-ki*, with a catch in the middle. That length is not decoration; a later lesson turns it into a rule.

Grammar Lens: stem, then tense, then person

English changes a verb by putting words **around** it: *I am, I was, I will be*. Tamil changes it by gluing pieces **onto the end** of it, always in the same order:

இரு + க்கிற் + ஏன் → இருக்கிறேன்

>

iru (be) + *-kkir-* (happening now) + *-ēn* (I) → *irukkirēn*

Left to right, the word says **be** — **present** — **I**. Three slots, filled in that order, welded into one word. Languages built this way are called **agglutinative**, from Latin *glutinare*, “to glue.”

Two payoffs arrive at once. The last piece already means “I,” so *nān* is optional. And nothing here belongs to *iru* alone: every verb in this chapter is the same three slots with a new first bead.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “iru” — be, exist, stay
- “irukkirēn” — I am
- the three beads in order — “iru ... kkir ... ēn”

Before you move on

What are the three pieces of *irukkirēn*, in order? (**Stem, tense, person** — *iru*, *-kkir-*, *-ēn*.) Which piece carries “I”? (**The last one**, *-ēn* — which is why *nān* can be dropped.) Which sister language kept the same verb? (**Kannada**, *iru*.) Next: the same machine, with the tense bead swapped.

32.2 போ (pō) — “to go,” and the bead that carries time

You have the three slots — stem, tense, person. Keep the first and last beads still, and swap only the middle one. That is the

whole of Tamil tense.

You'll want to know: போ

போ — *pō* — to go

Two letters, ப (*pa*) with the long-*ō* sign, and a word so old it has barely moved. It is native Dravidian: Telugu పోవు (*pōvu*) and Malayalam പോകുക (*pōkuka*) are the same verb.

Kannada's everyday word for “go” is ಹೋಗು (*hōgu*) — and that *h* is not a different root. It is the same softening of an old *p* that turned Tamil *pattu* (“ten”) into Kannada *hattu*. One sound-law, met once with numbers, now paying off with a verb.

You met the bare stem in the farewell chapter, where *pō!* is already a whole command: “go!”

Grammar Lens: past, present, future — one bead each

Hold the stem *pō-* and the person-ending *-ēn* (“I”) fixed, and let the middle piece do the work:

when	Tamil	the middle bead
now	<i>pōgirēn</i>	<i>-gir-</i>
already	<i>pōnēn</i>	<i>-n-</i>
not yet	<i>pōvēn</i>	<i>-v-</i>

“I go,” “I went,” “I will go” — one syllable of difference, sitting between two pieces that never moved. English needs a new word (*will*) or a whole new shape (*went*); Tamil needs one bead.

The tense bead voices to *-gir-* after a vowel, which is why it sounds like *pō-gi-rēn* here but *iruk-ki-rēn* after the doubled *k* of *iru*.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “*pō*” — go
- the three times — “*pōgirēn ... pōnēn ... pōvēn*”
- the pair that shares one sound-law — “*pattu ... hattu*”, “*pō ... hōgu*”
- “*irukkirēn*” and “*pōgirēn*” — one machine, two stems

Before you move on

Which of the three beads changes for tense? (**The middle one.**)
 Say “I will go.” (*Pōvēn.*) Is Kannada’s *hōgu* a different root from *pō*?
 (**No** — the same old *p* softened to *h*, exactly as in *pattu* and *hattu*.)
 Next: a verb whose stem refuses to sit still.

32.3 ವಾ (vā) — “to come,” and a stem with two shapes

Pō threads its beads on without a fuss. Its partner *vā* does not — and the farewell you learned long ago has been hiding the reason.

You’ll want to know: ವಾ

ವಾ — *vā* — to come

ವ (va) with the long-*ā* sign, and, like *pō*, a whole command on its own: *vā!*, “come!” Native Dravidian, and the family keeps it: Malayalam വരുക (*varuka*), Kannada ಬಾ (*bā*), Telugu రా (*rā*). Kannada’s *b* and Telugu’s *r* are two regular reshapings of the same old word, not three separate verbs.

Grammar Lens: the word you say it by is not the word you build on

Thread the beads onto *vā-* and you get nothing a Tamil speaker says. The suffixes attach to வரு- (*varu-*) instead:

varu- + *-gīr-* + *-ēn* → வருகிறேன் (*varugirēn*), “I come.”

Past: வந்தேன் (*vantēn*), “I came.” Future: வருவேன் (*varuvēn*).
 So a Tamil verb has a form you **call** it by — the bare command, the form a dictionary lists — and a form the beads actually **attach** to. For most verbs those are the same shape. For a handful of very common ones, of which *vā* is the commonest, they are not, and the pair simply has to be learned together: *vā*, *varu-*.

You have said this word already. The farewell போய் வருகிறேன் (*pōy varugirēn*) — “I go and come back” — is *pō* and *varu-* standing side by side, and that *varugirēn* is the very form above.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- the command — “vā!”
- the pair that must be learned together — “vā ... varu-”
- “varugirēn ... vantēn ... varuvēn”
- the farewell you now understand — “pōy varugirēn”

Before you move on

What shape do the beads attach to for “come”? (வரு-, *varu-*, not *vā-*.) Say “I come.” (*Varugirēn*.) Which two verbs are standing in *pōy varugirēn*? (போ and வா — go, and come back.) Are Kannada *bā* and Telugu *rā* different verbs? (No — the same Dravidian word, reshaped.) Next: a verb Tamil built for itself.

32.4 சாப்பிடு (*sāppiḍu*) — “to eat,” a verb built out of two words

Iru, *pō*, *vā* — three single syllables inherited whole from the oldest layer of Dravidian. The everyday word for “eat” is nothing of the kind. It was assembled.

You’ll want to know: சாப்பிடு

சாப்பிடு — *sāppiḍu* — to eat

Four beats: *sāp-pi-ḍu*, with the ப் held long, the same doubling you heard in *irukkirēn*. Threaded up, it is சாப்பிடுகிறேன் (*sāppiḍugirēn*), “I eat” — stem, then *-gir-*, then *-ēn*, with no surprises. Past: சாப்பிட்டேன் (*sāppittēn*).

The word, taken apart — its roots and family

The word comes apart cleanly into two Tamil words:

- சாப்பு (*sāppu*) — food, a meal; the everyday சாப்பாடு (*sāppāḍu*, “a meal”) is built from it.

- இடு (*idu*) — to put, to place.

Put food. That is all *sāppidu* literally says. இடு is what grammarians call a **light verb**: a plain, hard-working verb that lends its endings to a noun so the pair can act as one verb. Tamil builds a great many verbs this way, so *idu* is worth knowing on its own. (Where *sāppu* itself came from is not settled; treat the compound as transparent and the deeper root as open.)

Then the honest part. The inherited Dravidian word for eating is ***tin-**, and it is thriving next door: Telugu తిను (*tinu*), Kannada ತಿನ್ನು (*tinnu*), Malayalam തിന്നുക (*tinnuka*). Tamil kept it too, as தின் (*tin*) — now narrowed to chewing and snacking — and kept the old literary உண் (*un*), Malayalam’s ഉണ്ണുക (*uṇṇuka*), besides. So Tamil did not lose the ancient eat-verbs. It built a new one and let them keep their smaller jobs.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “sāppidu” — eat
- “sāppidugirēn” — I eat — then “sāppiṭṭēn”, I ate
- the two halves — “sāppu” (food) + “idu” (put)
- the inherited root next door — “tinu ... tinnu ... tinnuka”

Before you move on

What two words is *sāppidu* made of? (சாப்பு, food, and இடு, to put.) What is a light verb doing there? (**Lending its endings** to a noun so the pair works as one verb.) Did Tamil lose the inherited eat-root? (**No** — *tin* narrowed to chewing, *un* stayed literary, and the cousins kept *tinu*, *tinnu*, *tinnuka*.) Next: the verb that splits Tamil’s verbs into two classes.

32.5 பார் (pār) — “to see,” and Tamil’s two kinds of verb

Four verbs in, one small thing has been inconsistent. *Pōgīrēn* has a single *k*. *Irukkīrēn* has a doubled one. That is not sloppiness — it is a sorting rule, and this verb is where it gets a name.

You’ll want to know: பார்

பார் — *pār* — to see, to watch

ப with the long-*ā* sign, then ர் with a pulli to strip its vowel: *pār*, one syllable ending on the *r*. From it comes the noun பார்வை (*pārvai*), “sight, vision.”

Each Dravidian sister settled on a different everyday word for seeing — Kannada ನೋಡು (*nōḍu*), Telugu చూడు (*cūḍu*), Malayalam കാണുക (*kāṇuka*) — so *pār* is Tamil’s own choice, not the family’s. But the family’s shared root is here too: Tamil keeps காண் (*kāṇ*), “to see,” for formal and literary use, and that is the same word as Malayalam’s *kāṇuka* and Kannada’s ಕಾಣು (*kāṇu*). Four sisters, one inherited root, four everyday preferences.

Grammar Lens: strong verbs and weak verbs

Every Tamil verb belongs to one of two camps, and the tense bead tells you which:

camp	present	past
weak — <i>pō</i>	<i>pōgīrēn</i>	<i>pōnēn</i>
strong — <i>pār</i>	<i>pārkīrēn</i>	<i>pārttēn</i>

Weak verbs take the tense bead lightly: a single *k*, softened to *g*. **Strong** verbs double it — *-kkīr-*, held long — and take a doubled *t* in the past. *Iru* is strong, which is why “I am” was *irukkīrēn* and never *irugīrēn*. *Sāppiḍu* is weak, like *pō*.

There is no rule you can hear in the bare stem that tells you which camp a verb is in, so it is learned with the verb, the way a noun’s gender is learned in other languages. Two camps, though — not twenty. Meet a verb once in its present form and it is settled forever.

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “pār” — see, watch
- the contrast, holding the long *kk* — “pōgīrēn ... pārkkīrēn”
- the past pair — “pōnēn ... pārttēn”
- which camp each verb sits in — “iru strong, pō weak, sāppiḍu weak, pār strong”

Before you move on

What separates a strong verb from a weak one? (**The doubled consonant** in the tense bead — *pārkkīrēn* against *pōgīrēn*.) Which camp is *iru* in, and how do you know? (**Strong** — *irukkīrēn* holds the *kk*.) Which Tamil verb for “see” is shared with Malayalam and Kannada? (காண், *kāṇ* — kept for formal use beside everyday *pār*.) Next: a verb with no person on the end at all.

32.6 தெரி (teri) — “to know,” the verb that drops the person

Five verbs, and every one ended on *-ēn*, the bead that means “I.” The last verb of the chapter refuses that bead — and Chapter 6 already gave you the sentence it makes.

You’ll want to know: தெரி

தெரி — *teri* — to know; to be apparent, to be visible

த (*ta*) with the short-*e* sign, then ரி (*ri*). Its base sense is not “know” but “**show up, be clear**” — a thing *teri*-s to you the way a shape resolves out of fog. The everyday form is தெரியும் (*teriyum*): “it is known,” “it is apparent.”

Tamil keeps a second know-verb, அறி (*ari*), for knowing by learning — the same word as Kannada ಅರಿ (*ari*) and Malayalam അറിയുക (*ariyuka*). *Teri* has an exact cousin too: Telugu’s తెలుసు (*telusu*), from తెలియ (*teliyu*).

Grammar Lens: no person on the verb, so the person moves

எனக்குத் தமிழ் தெரியும். — *enakkut tamīl teriyum* —
“I know Tamil.”

Chapter 6 gave you that sentence whole; here is the verb inside it. தெரியும் has no person bead, and stays the same shape no matter who knows:

- *enakku teriyum* — it is known **to me**
- *unakku teriyum* — it is known **to you**
- *avanukku teriyum* — it is known **to him**

Only the little dative word in front changes. Tamil treats knowing as something that **happens to** you rather than something you **do**, so the knower is not the subject and cannot climb into the verb’s last slot. That is the chapter’s closing symmetry. Five verbs carried the person in the ending, and *nān* could be dropped. Here the ending carries no person, so the dative word is the one thing you cannot drop. Telugu builds it identically: నాకు తెలుసు (*nāku telusu*), “to me it is known.”

Your turn

Say these aloud:

- “teri” — be apparent — then “teriyum”, it is known
- “enakkut tamīl teriyum” — I know Tamil
- the three knowers, one verb — “enakku ... unakku ... avanukku teriyum”
- the five that carried the person — “irukkirēn, pōgirēn, varugirēn, sāppidugirēn, pārkirēn”

Before you move on

What does *teri* mean underneath “know”? (**To be apparent, to show up.**) Which bead is missing from *teriyum*? (**The person** — so the knower sits in the dative word instead.) Say “I know Tamil.”

(*Enakkut tamīl teriyum.*) Name the three slots one last time, with a strong verb in them. (**Stem, tense, person** — *pār* + *-kkir-* + *-ēn.*) Which sister builds the knowing-sentence the same way? (**Telugu**, *nāku telusu.*)

The Tamil script — a reference

Not to be read before the lessons — they teach reading through real words, each letter introduced as a word needs it. This page just gathers the system.

The three facts

1. **Consonants carry a built-in “a.”** க = ka, ம = ma, ர = ra.
2. **A vowel sign changes that built-in vowel.** ா = ā, ி = i, ீ = ī, ூ = u, ௃ = ū, ெ = e, ே = ē, ை = ai, ொ = o, ோ = ō.
(E.g. க ka + ி → கி ki.)
3. **A *pulli* (the dot, •) removes the built-in vowel.** க் = a bare *k*.
A vowel-less consonant then leans into the next.

Independent vowels (word-initial)

அ a · ஆ ā · இ i · ஈ ī · உ u · ஊ ū · எ e · ஏ ē · ஐ ai · ஒ o ·
ஔ ō · ஔ au.

What makes Tamil distinctive

- **Three *n*'s, three *l*'s, two *r*'s.** Place of articulation is written: dental ந / alveolar ண / retroflex ண்; ல ள ழ; ர ற. English fuses each set; Tamil keeps them apart, and they change meaning.
- **One letter, several sounds.** Tamil marks no voicing or aspiration: க can be *k*, *g*, or *h*; ச can be *s* or *ch* — **position** decides. The alphabet is small; the sound is read from context.

- **No Sanskrit-only letters in the core set.** Classical Tamil gets by with 18 consonants (a handful of *grantha* letters — ஜ, ஷ, ஸ, ஹ — are added only to spell loanwords).

Tamil in the Dravidian family

Tamil is the oldest-attested Dravidian language, and the one most protective of its native word-stock. Its sisters — Malayalam (closest), then Kannada and Telugu — share the grammar and many roots but borrowed far more freely from Sanskrit. The lessons trace, word by word, which Tamil words are home-grown and which its neighbours replaced.